

Tahqīq vs. *Taqlīd* in the Renaissances of Western Early Modernity

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Abstract

This essay reviews a major new study of European Renaissance Arabist-humanist philology as it was actually practiced, humanist neoclassicizing anti-Arabism notwithstanding. While definitive and philologically magisterial, that study nevertheless falls prey structurally and conceptually to the very eurocentrism whose ideological-textual genesis it chronicles. Situating it within the comparative global early modern philologies framework that has now been proposed in the volume *World Philology* and the present journal is a necessary remedy—but only a partial one; for that framework too still obscures the multiplicity of specifically genetically *Western* early modernities, thus hobbling comparative history of philology. I therefore propose a new framework appropriate to the study of Greco-Arabo-Persian and Greco-Arabo-Latin as the two parallel and equally powerful philosophical-philological trajectories that together defined early modern Western—i.e., Hellenic-Abrahamic, Islamo-Judeo-Christian, west of South India—intellectual history: *tahqīq* vs. *taqlīd*, progressivism vs. declinism.

But a broadened and more balanced analytical framework alone cannot save philology, much less Western civilization, from the throes of its current existential crisis: for we philologists of the Euro-American academy are fevered too by the cosmological ill that is reflexive scientistic materialism. As antidote, I prescribe a progressivist, postmodern return to early modern Western deconstructive-reconstructive *cosmic philology* as prerequisite for the discipline's survival, and perhaps even triumph, in the teeth of totalitarian colonialist-capitalist modernity.

* My thanks to Islam Dayeh, Wouter Hanegraaff, Nükhet Varlık, Mana Kia, Daniel Sheffield, Nicholas Harris and Noah Gardiner for their comments on a draft of this article, and to Andrew Berns for the woody conversations that inspired it.

Keywords

Renaissance Arabism – humanism – neoclassicism – progressivism – materialism – neopythagoreanism – Greco-Arabo-Persian – Greco-Arabo-Latin – global early modernities – world philology – liberation philology

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Dag Nikolaus Hasse. *Success and Suppression: Arabic Sciences and Philosophy in the Renaissance.* Cambridge [MASS]: Harvard University Press, 2016. 660 pp. ISBN 978-0-674-97158-5. \$59.95.

Sheldon Pollock, Benjamin A. Elman and Ku-ming Kevin Chang, eds. *World Philology.* Cambridge [MASS]: Harvard University Press, 2015. 452 pp. ISBN 978-0-674-05286-4. \$46.50.

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You've raised aloft the banner of imitation
and razed flat the temple of verification.
Heed, yes—but don't follow so blindly,
so slavishly, your forebears.
You're but being suppressive:
God's curse be upon you and your imitation!

SHAH ṬAHMĀSB I TO 'UBAYD ALLĀH KHAN (1532)¹

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The intellectual history of the European Renaissance is defined by a perennial philological tension between *taḥqīq* and *taqlīd*, or independent inquiry and blind imitation, with respect to its Greco-Arabic patrimony. Hardliner

¹ *Rāyat-i taqlīd bar-afrākhtī / khāna-yi taḥqīq bar-andākhtī // bi-shnaw u bisyār muqallid ma-bāsh / tābi'-i ajdād bidīn jidd ma-bāsh // hast bi taqlīd chū taqyid-i tū / la'nat-i ḥaqq bar tū u taqlīd-i tū.* The Safavid letter, a confrontational response to an equally confrontational Uzbek letter, is preserved in 'Abd al-Ḥusayn Ṭūsī's (fl. 16th c.) *Munsha'āt*, ed. in 'Abd al-Ḥusayn Navā'ī, *Shāh Ṭahmāsb-i Ṣafavī: Majmū'a-yi Asnād u Mukātabāt-i Tārīkhī* (Tehran: Intishārāt-i Bunyād-i Farhang-i Irān, 1350 Sh./1971), 37; cited in Colin P. Mitchell, *The Practice of Politics in Safavid Iran: Power, Religion and Rhetoric* (London: I.B. Tauris, 2009), 75 (translation mine).

humanists, as is well known, committed to a purely European *prisca sapientia*, pushed for an extreme *taqlid* of Greek sources to the exclusion of Arabic; but this they did in reaction to the unprecedented success of Arabism in European scholarly circles—whence the boom in the printing of Latin editions of Arabic texts in the 15th and 16th centuries. And even these ideological purificationists could not avoid the scientific seductions of *taḥqīq*, a province dominated by Arabic, which their strict Grecism was far too narrow, too impractical, to sustain. Scholarly compromises abounded. Arabism thus remained essential to Renaissance scientific-philosophical inquiry, as a host of less ideologically-motivated scholars freely acknowledged. Nevertheless, humanists did succeed in tarnishing its sheen in some fields, on grounds variously ideological and scientific, especially philosophy and astrology (they had much less success in medicine); they also attempted to camouflage indispensable Arabic sources by grecizing them. Yet it was rarely the *Islamicness* of Arabic sources that was at issue for these Christian scholars, but rather simply their *post-Greekness*.

As that may be, the triumph of humanist ideology, while decidedly partial at the time, was not short-lived; indeed, it has since become total. For Renaissance anti-Arabic polemics, positing a neat and newly eurocentric Greek-Latin teleology wherein Arabic can serve as but alien surrogate for Greek, are the genesis of the narrative of *Islamic* decline vs. European florescence in the early modern period—which narrative, wildly fictitious and wholly pernicious, was weaponized under colonialism and continues to structure both popular and scholarly discourse in the Euro-American present.

So argues Dag Nikolaus Hasse in *Success and Suppression: Arabic Sciences and Philosophy in the Renaissance*, a sweeping and erudite summary of the current state of the field of Renaissance and Arabic-to-Latin studies that draws heavily on the author's own work and that of Charles Burnett in particular.² This quintessentially Warburgian study seeks precisely to sidestep Renaissance and modern polemic alike to show, in great philological detail, not the posturings of Renaissance scholars vis-à-vis their Arabic heritage but how those scholars actually engaged it. It is divided into two parts of three chapters each: the first documents the boom in Arabist-humanist scholarship in 15th- and 16th-century Europe, as evidenced by the printing of editions, university curricula, biographical writing and a new Arabic-Latin and Hebrew-Latin translation movement; the second investigates the (partially successful) humanist backlash against this boom, focusing on those three scholarly fields

2 Hasse does not, of course, employ the terms *taḥqīq* and *taqlid*; their analytical relevance to a broader early modern Western intellectual history is discussed below.

of inquiry most heavily dependent on Arabic sources and so scene to the most pro-Greek, anti-Arabic polemic: philosophy, medicine-pharmacology and astrology. The concluding seventh chapter synthesizes the preceding six to address the cultural consequences of such polemic, and the degree to which it was or was not scientifically justified. Finally, a sizable appendix inventories the availability of Arabic authors and texts in the Latin editions printed during the Renaissance, focusing on philosophy and the sciences, and excluding anonymous texts (particularly the *Ps.-Aristotelica*), vernacular translations and authors left unprinted.

As an Islamicist and a specialist in the occult sciences, I will give disproportionate attention in what follows to chapter six, treating of astrology, as a case study representative of the whole; I then limn the broader early modern Western—that is, Helleno-Islamo-Judeo-Christian—intellectual-historical and philological contexts in which this book is most profitably to be read. Most importantly, this comparative procedure will suggest, Hasse's rigorously philological history of Renaissance philology yet testifies eloquently to the massive imbalances and ideological perversions that have hobbled and still hobble the modern discipline itself. We must revive and cosmologically reconceptualize philology, lest it, and we, perish.

Renaissance Arabo-Latinism: The Texts

The textual basis for early modern Arabo-Latinism, the bulk of which was generated during the translation movement in 12th-century Iberia, underwent signal changes between the medieval scholastic period and the Renaissance: not only was it slightly expanded through a modest rash of new translations, either directly from Arabic or via Hebrew, but certain authors came into vogue (and hence were frequently printed) and others went out (and hence were little printed or left unprinted), and biographies began to be written of the most popular Arabic authors. Yet even at its peak, the Arabic influence on Renaissance scholarship, while of central importance, remained strikingly narrow, uneven and static—and thus significantly divergent from contemporary developments in Arabic philosophy and science. “[I]n philosophy, the influence was strongest in natural philosophy, psychology, and metaphysics, and weaker in ethics and logic; in the sciences, there was a strong impact on medicine, astrology, astronomy, trigonometry, algebra, zoology, and the occult sciences, but less influence on other sciences, such as geometry and botany” (5). One author in particular became the object of veritable obsession in Latin to a degree he never enjoyed in his native Arabic: Ibn Rushd (Averroes), Aristotle commentator

nonpareil. The boom in Averroism so definitive of Renaissance philosophy—and so absent from early modern Islamic—is reflected in the fact that editions of Ibn Rushd's commentaries, often incorporating Aristotle's base text, were printed far more times than those of any other Arabic author (a remarkable 114, to be precise), and new translations even made (via Hebrew) in the late 15th century, including one financed by Giovanni Pico della Mirandola himself. (This is despite the fact that many humanists and theologians came to denounce the Andalusian aristotelian as an irreligious philosopher.) At 78, 72 and 67 editions each respectively, Ibn Sīnā (Avicenna), Ibn Māsawayh (Mesue and Ps.-Mesue) and Abū Bakr Rāzī (Rhazes) were the first runners-up, though almost exclusively in the field of medicine-pharmacology: in a significant departure from medieval scholasticism, Ibn Sīnā the physician far outstripped Ibn Sīnā the philosopher in Renaissance curricula. Of similarly seminal influence—and that of similarly peculiar unevenness and staticness—was Arabic astrology, which saw a greater range of authors being printed fewer times; most popular was al-Qabīṣī (Alcabitius), with 13 editions printed between the 15th and 16th centuries. Textual improvements made by printers and scholars aside, however, the Arabo-Latin astrological corpus remained that established, rather haphazardly, by the 13th century; no new translations were made.

Chapter 1 introduces the Latin printed editions of these and other Arabic authors that formed the backbone of Renaissance university curricula. As Hasse summarizes in a revealing chart (8), 44 Arabic authors altogether were made available in Latin printed editions by the 17th century, when massive printing projects came abruptly to an end; and these far outstripped in impact the editions prepared by scholastic authors like Peter Abelard and Roger Bacon. (Indeed, scholastic Latin itself became a major target of Renaissance polemic: humanists decried it as too decadent—because too *Arabicized*.) Given their considerable expense, the printing projects undertaken most notably in Venice, Lyon, Basel, Paris, Nuremberg, Strasbourg and Pavia were necessarily market-driven; “[a]uthors who did not sell had little chance to be printed again” (9). In university curricula, the main and most oft-printed authorities were thus “Galen and Avicenna in medicine, Aristotle and Averroes in philosophy, and Ptolemy, Alcabitius, and Albumasar in astrology. The students of universities of the Christian world read very few Christian authors ... The bulk of teaching was on Greek and Arabic authors” (17). Pharmacology, uniquely, was institutionalized both within and outside the university, with pharmacists being trained through apprenticeship since the medieval period; here Ibn Māsawayh was a primary authority. The triumvirate of Avicenna, Rhazes and Mesue together remained on medical curricula until the 18th century—the ardent efforts of humanists to de-Arabicize university curricula all notwithstanding. But even they too

began to be phased out in the 17th, as testified to by a decline in the printing of editions of their works. Humanists were significantly more successful in their de-Arabicizing project in other fields, and especially astrology, a point I will expand on below.

“[T]he transmission and teaching of Arabic authors in the Renaissance,” in sum, “differed from the medieval transmission, in spite of all continuities”—in particular, Ibn Sīnā’s *Metaphysics* and *De anima*, Fārābī’s *De scientiis*, Qusṭā b. Lūqā’s *De differentia spiritus et animae*, the Ps.-Aristotelian *Liber de causis* and various works on mathematics and astronomy by Khwārazmī, Farghānī and Thābit b. Qurra declined in importance, while other works boomed in popularity: “Mesue’s pharmacology, Avicenna’s [and Rhazes’s] medicine, Averroes’s philosophy, and Albumasar’s astrology were major reference points for the work of Renaissance scholars” (26). But it was precisely their overwhelming dependency on Arabic authors that aroused the insecurity and ire of humanists, who sought vigorously to demote Arabic culture from its wonted status as “source culture of equal rank with the Greek and the Roman” (3). The epochal transmission of Greek to Arabic would increasingly be styled in Renaissance humanist polemic not the salvation of Western learning but its *shipwreck*.

Like the textual transmission of Arabic authors to Latin, the biographical content of Renaissance chronicles and treatises on famous men both continues the medieval scholastic tradition and breaks with it: Arabic authors are now introduced. In Chapter 2, Hasse inquires into the motives that led to the rise of the bio-bibliographical study of these authors—“whether, for example, historical, philological, medical, religious, anecdotal, or orientalist” (28)—vis-à-vis the intellectual trends of the time. Also important as a countervailing factor was the developing genre of histories of scientific disciplines, including medicine and mathematics, fully mature by the 16th century; these too begin inserting Arabic authors from the 14th century onward, and served as source for Renaissance world historians. Nevertheless, Renaissance images of Arabic authors were created by biographers who lacked “access to any significant sources on their lives and works” (*ibid.*), and hence epitomize the cultural imaginary specific to contemporary Europe; therein a *eurocentrizing* impulse is very much on display.

Here Hasse takes three Arabic authors as exempla: Ibn Sīnā, Ibn Rushd and Abū Ma’shar. What little medieval biographical data existed on these celebrated authorities is generally suspect, and often wildly fictitious; they put, for example, Abū Ma’shar in Athens and Ibn Rushd’s sons in Sicily, and make Ibn Sīnā a Spaniard and a king. Many of these errors are perpetuated, and fresh fictions added, in the Renaissance bio-bibliographical tradition—an

increasingly important site of humanist anti-Arabist polemic, as well as pro-Arabist pushback.

The first universal history to include Arabic scholars' bio-bibliographies is Jacopo Filippo Foresti da Bergamo's (d. 1520) *Supplementum chronicarum* of 1483, "the standard world chronicle of the Renaissance" (66), which groups them, significantly, with Christian scholastics, not among ancient or pagan authors. His focus is almost exclusively on medical authors, and he includes 11 Arabic scholars mainly from the period 982-1158, of whom nine became canonical: Averroes, Avicenna, Rhazes, Mesue, Avenzoar (Ibn Zuhr), Isaac Israeli (Ishāq al-Isrā'īlī), Serapion (Ibn Sarābiyūn), and Albaterius (al-Biṭrīq)—as well as, curiously, the pseudohistorical Arab king "Evax" of the first century CE. This is in sharp contrast to 14th- and 15th-century precedent, wherein, "[f]or a Christian writer, the Arabs were too pagan, and from the humanist point of view, they were too barbarous and too medieval to deserve attention" (30). Significantly, Foresti da Bergamo is responsible for a purely positive image of Ibn Rushd that was to have considerable attraction through the 17th century, and contributed not a little to the rise of Renaissance Averroism. (Fantastically, however, he reports that the Cordoban philosopher personally poisoned Ibn Sīnā, his great rival, who nevertheless succeeded in avenging himself on Ibn Rushd before perishing.) The historian's strong preference for medical authors over astrological likewise had a long afterlife in the Renaissance biographical tradition.

Foresti influenced in the first place the world historian Hartmann Schedel (d. 1514), author of the famed *Liber chronicarum* or Nuremburg chronicle, first printed in its original Latin and in German translation in 1493; its "treatment of Arabic authors is a curious mixture of scholarly investigation and colorful invention" (39). Schedel's hispanizing tendency is particularly pronounced: he transmogrifies Ibn Sīnā, Fārābī and even Ghazālī into mid-12th-century Andalusian alter egos of Ibn Rushd. A second important heir is Simon de Phares (d. ca. 1500), one of the most famous astrologers of his day, who produced in defense of his profession the *Recueil des plus célèbres astrologues*. This, the first extant European history of astrology (as distinct from astronomy), is even more biographically fantastical than Schedel's chronicle: it takes over and transforms Foresti's medical authors into astrologers, all textual and biographical data to the contrary notwithstanding. He also considerably expands Foresti's small group of Arabic authorities to include Abraham b. Ezra, Albohali (Abū 'Alī al-Khayyāt), Alubater (Ibn al-Khaṣīb), Albucasis (al-Zahrāwī), (Ps.-)Almansor (al-Isrā'īlī), Azarchel (al-Zarqālī), Jafar Indus (?), Haly filius Abbas ('Alī b. al-'Abbās al-Majūsī), Haly filius Abenragel (Abū l-Ḥasan 'Alī Ibn Abī l-Rijāl), Messahalal (Māshā'allāh), Omar Tiberiadis ('Umar b. al-Farrukhān al-Ṭabarī),

Thebit ben Corat (Thābit b. Qurra) and Zahel (Sahl b. Bishr). Most notably, Simon is the first to provide a biography of Abū Ma'shar—whom he both places in Athens and splits into several persons.

Following Foresti's historiographical lead in particular, the first treatise on famous men to include Arabic authors appeared at the turn of the 16th century: Johann Staindel's (d. 1508) *Suppletio virorum illustrium* of 1497, focusing on philosophers and poets; and the circa 1506 *De medicine claris scriptoribus* of the "enigmatic and belligerent" Symphorien Champier (d. 1538), Lyonese physician and humanist (42). While the latter history of medicine improves in places on Foresti's, it hints at its author's later emergence as a major anti-Arabic polemicist: in his entry on Ibn Sīnā, Champier twists the Muslim philosopher's words to paint him as a devastating critic of Islamic law and theology, and indeed an enlightened denier of the prophethood of Muḥammad, that "carnal and stupid dragon" (44). Some 15 years later, as editor of the *Canon*, Champier would attempt to deter readers from Ibn Sīnā "by inserting before the proper text a seventeen-page refutation of Avicenna's philosophical and medical errors" (53).

The *De viris quibusdam illustribus apud arabes* of al-Ḥasan b. Muḥammad al-Wazzān al-Zayyātī (d. 1554), aka Leo Africanus, stands as an anomaly in this context: testifying to its celebrated Fezzi author's shaky grasp of Latin, this is the only biographical work of the period to a) actually draw on Arabic sources, and b) exhibit a decidedly "postclassical" focus. Both virtues reflect the far greater ambition and scope of the Arabic biographical tradition as compared to the Latin, which in turn reflects the comparatively backwater status of medieval and Renaissance Europe vis-à-vis the far more cosmopolitan and wealthy contemporary Islamicate world; the latter accordingly boasted a much more numerous scholarly elite who might merit biographical notice, and so Arabic biographical dictionaries often feature *thousands* of entries where Latin cognates mention mere *dozens*. At the same time, however, Leo largely agrees with Foresti as to the most important Arabic authors, and like him focuses on physicians and philosophers (while also adding theologians); curiously enough, Leo's entries are at times equally unreliable. (His account of Ibn Sīnā is particularly fanciful.) Strangely, given the fame of the same author's *Descrittione dell'Africa*, the *De viris* survives in but a single manuscript, and seems to have remained unknown until the second half of the 17th century; this fusion of Arabic and Latin bio-bibliographical traditions, "by far the most detailed source on Arabic scholars in the Renaissance" (51), thus had no corrective impact on Renaissance works in this vein.

An extreme paucity of data notwithstanding, Konrad Gesner's (d. 1565) *Bibliotheca universalis* of 1545 considerably enlarged the Foresti-Schedel-

Champier tradition, adding new entries on Arabic natural philosophers and astronomer-astrologers in particular; it “thus mirrors the considerable presence of Arabic authors on the international book market” (56). Significantly, and “only a few years after the attacks on Arabic learning had reached their culmination in the 1530s” (59), the Swiss scientist and philologist passes severe humanistic judgment not on the original Arabic works he treats but rather on their medieval Latin translations, which he often castigates as *barbarous*. Thus he argues, for example, in his biography on Abū Ma’shar, only the second in Latin, which “tallies well with the boom of Arabic general astrology in sixteenth-century Europe” (60).

Indeed, up to the late 16th century, Renaissance biographers focused on Arabic astrology to the almost total exclusion of Arabic astronomy and mathematics, this despite the fact that Arabic astronomical texts were readily available in manuscripts and printed editions—a striking imbalance that Bernardino Baldi (d. 1617) finally attempted to remedy. Most known for his commentary on Ps.-Aristotle’s *Mechanica problemata*, the Italian abbot’s *Le vite de’ matematici* (1596), considerably less fanciful than the works above, includes among its 202 biographies those of 14 (or rather 13) Arabic mathematician-astronomers: Messala (Māshā’allāh), Albategno (al-Battānī), Alī Alboazeno (Ibn Abī l-Rijāl), Arzahele (al-Zarqālī), Abenrodano (Ibn Riḍwān), Almansore (al-Isrā’īlī), Alhazen (Ibn al-Haytham), Alchindo (al-Kindī), Alpetragio (al-Bīṭrūjī), Gebro (Jābir b. Aflaḥ), Alfagrano (al-Farghānī), Tebitte (Thābit b. Qurra) and Albumasar (Abū Ma’shar). “[I]f he discusses astrologers, it is only with respect to their contributions to astronomy” (62). While he valorizes these Arabic authors for their scientific exactness and new planetary theories, Baldi’s presentation of the “cross-cultural Ptolemaic tradition” (63) is unprecedentedly teleological and supersessionist: Greek-Arabic-Latin.

The Foresti bio-bibliographical tradition, as surveyed here by Hasse, thus testifies to the slow, meager, unreliable and frequently highly tendentious Renaissance receptions of information about the lives and works of Arabic authors, which were variously subject to Christian critique, fantastical embellishment, hellen- or hispanization, and even (if rarely) outright islamophobia. As such, they serve as index of the gradual burgeoning of the new humanist movement. The biographical portrayals of Abū Ma’shar, as Albumasar, are a typical case of Renaissance anti-Arabic polemic, characteristically based on wildly speculative and sparse accounts. He is variously made into a Spaniard or an Athenian; Pico styles this, the father of conjunction astrology, a simple grammarian and mere astrologaster. In the 16th and 17th centuries, “Albumasar” came to feature in popular culture as a term of abuse designating incompetent, fraudster astrologers, irreligious consorters

with devils, even Saracenic tyrants—this in sharp contrast to the high esteem in which he was held by such scholars as Simon de Phares, Gesner and Baldi. Nevertheless, even their unprecedented bio-bibliographical valorization of Arabic authors like Abū Ma'shar was advanced on the basis of an explicitly *progressivist* Greek-Arabic-Latin teleology; they are curious not a whit as to contemporary Arabic developments. Their more radical humanist peers, on the contrary, as strict *declinists*, often simply occult the middle term altogether; for them modern progress could “only be achieved by reforms made in the spirit of ancient science” (68). Accordingly, the Foresti tradition was ultimately marginalized in the second half of the 16th century, when “Arabic scholars disappear again from world history” (64).

Chapter 3 turns to the question of Renaissance Arabic, and Hebrew, *philology*. As Hasse argues, far more important than the Renaissance bio-bibliographical tradition to the shaping of Arabo-Latin culture were the many new translation projects, some via Hebrew, a push that began in the 1480s—almost two hundred years since the great medieval Arabic-Latin translation movements had ceased—and persisted for over seven decades. “It is characterized by two major projects: first, the Latin rendering of Averroes's commentaries, which were not yet available in Latin, and second, the replacing of the medieval version of Avicenna's *Canon medicinae* by more modern and reliable translations” (69). Other important translations include the *De motibus caelorum* of Alpetragius (al-Bīṭrūjī), the *De mundo et coelo* of Alhazen (Ibn al-Haytham) and the short psychological tracts of Avicenna. Moreover, some translators and revisers accomplished their work on the basis of manuscript copies personally procured in the Levant, such as Girolamo Ramusio (d. 1486) and Andrea Alpago (d. 1522), physicians to the Venetian embassy in Damascus. Yet the impact of the Renaissance translation movement, unlike its medieval predecessor, has been little studied; as a preliminary to such study, Hasse therefore examines the philological quality and competing ideological features of this movement, as well as its social setting, which combined several different milieus: “academic professors, Jewish translators, aristocratic patrons, humanist scholars, and travelers in the Near East” (71).

To this end, Hasse offers a comparative study of five translation projects in particular, all of which involved multiple translations of the same texts: “Averroes's preface to *Metaphysics* 12, Averroes's Middle commentary on the *Topics*, Avicenna's *Canon*, Averroes's medical opus *Colliget* (*Kitāb al-Kullīyyāt*), and Pseudo-Mesue's *Opera omnia*” (71). (A full list of Renaissance Arabic-Latin translations is provided in Table 2.) Here he confronts “what the translators say they do with what they in fact do in the philological detail” (*ibid.*); Hasse further defends the justness of the application of the term philology to both

medieval and Renaissance translations, which manifestly seek “to improve the transmitted text of another author by solving technical textual problems” (76).

“It is with Elia del Medigo” (d. 1493)—a Jewish Averroist scholar from Crete, author on cosmology and psychology and translator—“that the story of Arabic-Latin and Hebrew-Latin translations in the Renaissance opens” (77). Most notably, he was the first to translate, via Hebrew, Averroes’s preface to book 12 of his Long commentary on the *Metaphysics*, among a number of other works by the same philosopher, thus filling a gap left by Michael Scot (d. ca. 1235). This new translation push reflects the intellectual climate of the University of Padua in particular, then an important center of Renaissance Averroism. The same seminal text was again translated, independently, by Paolo Ricci (d. 1541), aka “Paulus Israelita,” Habsburg court physican and major promoter of the new Christian kabbalah associated in the first place with Pico della Mirandola; and a third time by the Spanish professor of medicine and physician to the pope Jacob Mantino (d. 1549), preeminent Renaissance translator of Averroes. Significantly, both Ricci and Mantino pour philological scorn on medieval translations, which they dismiss as corrupt, barbarous and mutilated—such antischolasticism, like anti-Arabism, being an index of humanism’s burgeoning. By contrast, del Medigo’s translation of Averroes’s preface is hyperliteral, overcorrect and semiticizing—in short, of notably poor Latinity, and, ironically, more Arabicized and hence scholastic than its medieval predecessors. (A similar defect plagues Abraham de Balmes’s (d. 1523) translation of Averroes’s Middle commentary on the *Topics*, which is in fact significantly inferior to scholastic cognates.) Yet Ricci’s “ostentatiously humanist Latin” (84), featuring an elaborate classical style “entirely unheard of in the history of *Averroes latinus*” (85), goes to the opposite extreme; he necessarily adds to and distorts the sense of the Hebrew translation he worked from, itself rather divergent from the versions used by del Medigo and Mantino. That is to say, the classicizing impulse so emblematic of humanism “is a tactic of doubtful value for translating scientific or philosophical texts ... [for it] introduces rather than avoids errors” (86-87). Mantino’s translation, closely reliant on but also thoroughgoingly corrective of del Medigo’s, therefore represents a middle, ultimately more effective path: its mildly classicizing approach de-semiticizes without seriously distorting its (slightly distorted) Hebrew source, producing a less gorgeous but more reliable, philosophically clear and readable Latin Averroes—virtues that would come to be much appreciated by the Andalusian philosopher’s eager Renaissance audience.³

3 Needless to say, the more thoroughgoingly de-semiticizing approach of Renaissance translators like Ricci, a convert from Judaism, reflects the wider Christian anti-Jewish sentiment

If Mantino proved reasonable philological-scientific precision in rendering Arabic texts into Latin was possible, if rare, for translators ignorant of Arabic, Andrea Alpago's annotations to Avicenna's *Canon*—"among the most impressive philological achievements of the Renaissance translation movement" (114)—and Girolamo Ramusio's interlinear "translation" of the same show a mastery of the original language itself to be *sine qua non* to the philological imperative to increase the *veritas lectionis*, the 'truth of reading,' of those texts so central to Renaissance scholarship. Such a conclusion is hardly surprising, of course; but few indeed were the scholars able to realize this Renaissance ideal. Mantino's wholly new translation of the *Canon*, based on Hebrew and reflecting his personal expertise in medicine, is thus as admirable as his Averroes translations; but it was only when "Benedetto Rinio integrated Alpago's emendations into his edition of the *Canon* in 1555 [that] the Latin transmission of the *Canon* was definitely lifted to a higher level of precision" (ibid.). By contrast, the revised translations made by humanist scholars ignorant of both Arabic and Hebrew could hardly improve on the 12th-century translation by Gerard of Cremona, whose primary defect was the textual corruption that had crept in over the intervening three centuries of Latin manuscript transmission. Most notably, the committed humanist Miguel Jerónimo Ledesma's (d. 1547) claim to have restored Avicenna to his 'Arabic truth' (*Avicennam ... ad arabicam veritatem ... emendare*) (ibid.) was baldly bogus; he simply reworked Gerard's translation, often further deforming or simply eliding the sense of Ibn Sinā's original. As such, it epitomizes the gulf that often yawned between the stated, programmatic claims of Renaissance humanists and the actual results of their translation work.

For all its philological shortcomings, however, the Arabic-Hebrew-Latin translation movement was of crucial importance to the development of Renaissance scholarship, classicizing or otherwise, and was patronized by some of the most prominent aristocratic humanists of the era; it merits much further study as such. Indeed, humanist ideals profoundly influenced the translation techniques of various translators and revisers, though with a variety of outcomes. Some renderings are but interpretations or revisions masquerading as translations, which frequently betray their source texts in

that was twin to humanist anti-Arabism. Philosophy aside, moreover, Hebrew texts were subject to censorship as a rule, whereby Renaissance scholars purged—in many cases quite successfully—anti-Christian elements to create an approved Hebrew canon; see Amnon Raz-Krakotzkin, *The Censor, the Editor, and the Text: The Catholic Church and the Shaping of the Jewish Canon in the Sixteenth Century*, trans. Jackie Feldman (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2007).

favor of a classicizing Latin style on the one hand or in pursuit of increased scientific accuracy on the other; others are true translations, if often of Hebrew intermediaries, that seek to balance contemporary sensibilities and needs with philological fidelity to the texts. (Belonging to the latter camp, the two translators who “achieved most in terms of quality are Andrea Alpago and Jacob Mantino, the worthy successors of the great translators of the Middle Ages” [131].) Some translators even sought out Arabic, Hebrew or Latin manuscripts to repair corrupted scholastic transmissions. This “concern for extinguishing corruptions and for retrieving better source material was much more widespread among Renaissance translators than among their medieval predecessors” (130), and testifies precisely to new humanist attitudes toward the text. “Hence, in spite of the humanist polemics against Arabic sciences in the Renaissance, it would be wrong to conceive of humanist and Arabist traditions as two antagonistic movements. In the translation movement, they were intertwined” (ibid.).

Renaissance Humanism: Greeks vs. Arabs

In part two of this study, Hasse turns from the *textual contours* of Renaissance humanism and (Hebrao-)Arabism to their *ideological impact* to limn the extent—often limited, and long contested—to which humanist anti-Arabism actually succeeded in ideologically suppressing or scientifically superseding the Arabic sources then coming into such wide circulation through printing. Again, to this end he focuses on those three scholarly fields of inquiry that became scene to the most pro-Greek, anti-Arabic polemic, devoting a chapter to each: epistemology, *materia medica* and astrology.

Despite the prevalence of humanist authors among the ranks of physicians, that field where humanist polemic had the least success was medicine; where the most, astrology. Yet it was medicine, more than any other science, that “was subject to the most substantial and dramatic attempts of humanist reform or refurbishment,” with medical humanist anti-Arabism reaching its climax “in an international debate in the 1520s and 1530s” (137). A similar debate raged in philosophy, with Averroes, *the* most influential Arabic author in the Renaissance, the ultimate Greek commentator who yet lacks Greek, as pivot balancing rhetorical extremes. Some, like Marsilio Ficino, decried the Andalusian heretic’s insidious undermining of (Christian) religion; others, like Pico della Mirandola, avidly commissioned new translations of the works of Aristotle’s *fidelissimus interpres*. Inquisitors threatened with excommunication those who publicly taught certain Averroan doctrines; philosophers censured

those who apostatized from the same. The popular Renaissance image of Averroes being crushed underfoot by Aquinas thus represents only one side of the debate—one never conclusively resolved. Ibn Rushd, in short, stands as both “a symbol of Christian Europe’s openness to philosophical thinking and of the great tensions that this openness created in a heterogeneous society” (179).

Exemplifying these tensions is a characteristically belligerent and furious passage in Leonhart Fuchs’s (d. 1566) *Paradoxorum medicinae libri tres* of 1535, which “combines the humanist appeal to return to antiquity (*ad fontes*) with anti-Islamic polemics” (137–38). As the latter are quite unusual, they mark the extreme limit to which humanist anti-Arabic polemic—rarely realized in practice—reached. I quote Hasse’s translation in full:

In the past, I had never imagined that studying Arabic authorities could be so pernicious as I realize now. I understand more clearly every day how much they are able to jeopardize, and I confess freely that I have treated them much too mildly in the past. One has to treat them much stricter, at least for the sake of posterity to prevent them from entering blindly the Arabic brothels (*ne arabica illa lupanaria incidant improvidi*). I declare publicly in front of everybody that I shall be the toughest enemy of the Arabs, that I will invest greater labor than before and besiege their strongholds and do not cease to do so until I have completely taken them, if God blesses me with a long life. For who could endure witnessing this pest raging any longer among the people? Nobody, to be sure—except those who desire the extinction of men, and of the Christians in particular. Instead let us proceed to the sources (*ad fontes potius pergamus*) and scoop the pure water, which is free of any dirt.

Hasse then provides a useful typology of anti-Arabic arguments, here with reference to medicine but more generally applicable to philosophy and the sciences: Arabic sources are confused and error-ridden, due both to Arabic authors’ own ignorance of Greek and to corruption in their transmission in Latin, especially given the barbarousness of the medieval translations. And even the original Arabic translations of Greek are unreliable, “since in these translations, as Fuchs put it, ‘many things were added by the translators against the intention of the Greeks, and many things omitted’” (138). Some polemicists went further to style “the Arabs” mere plagiarists, parasitically living off the work of their Greek betters. Thus, again, Fuchs: “‘The Arabs, many as they were, have not aimed at anything else than to consume, just as drones, the supplies of someone else’s labor and to wear foreign and even stolen plumes’” (139).

So much for rhetoric; Hasse sidesteps the smoke-and-mirrors of such polemic “to investigate the controversy internally by concentrating on the changing approaches to a specific technical problem” (ibid.)—a procedure he follows in each of the three chapters of the book’s second part. For reasons of space, I therefore turn to Chapter 6, “Ptolemy against the Arabs,” to examine the instructive case of astrology in some detail. For “hardly any other science in medieval and Renaissance culture was based as massively on Arabic sources” (292), and therefore as central to the Greeks vs. Arabs debate; but the fact that Arabic astrology was considerably less institutionalized than Arabic medicine and philosophy made it especially vulnerable to humanist critique.

The Case of Astrology

The 15th to 17th centuries represent, quite simply, the golden age of astrology in the West. (This emphatically includes the Islamicate world, as we shall see.) This queen of the practical-theoretical sciences enjoyed unprecedented popularity among elites and commoners alike: “[a]strological advice was valued by kings and popes, citizens and peasants, the educated and the uneducated, and it was offered by a great range of astrologers, from university teachers to city physicians and mere fortune tellers” (248). The discovery of printing led promptly to the mass production of astrological predictions in pamphlets, often written in the vernacular; populaces, especially Protestant, were much exercised by prognostications of the end of the Roman Empire, the second coming of Christ and the end of the world, with 1583, the year of a major Saturn-Jupiter conjunction (and herald of the Islamic millennium), being especially trumpeted. The printing of such apocalyptic predictions “declined only toward the very end of the sixteenth century” (ibid.). Practical applications aside, astrology also emerged as a primary site of theoretical debate; luminaries like Melanchthon, Cardano and Kepler actively sought to improve upon Greek-Arabic precedent, and at many universities the science formed part of the regular curriculum in mathematics and medicine: Ptolemy, al-Qabīṣī and Abū Ma’shar in particular became required reading.

To serve this new academic market, altogether the astrological works of 11 Arabic authors were made available in print, and some editorially improved or printed with commentaries: Albohali, Albubater, Albumasar, Alcabitius, Alkindi, Haly filius Abenragel, Haly Rodioan (Ibn Riḍwān), Ps.-Almansor, Messahalāh, Omar Tiberiadis, and Zahel. “The most oft-printed astrological work of Arabic origin was Alcabitius’s (al-Qabīṣī’s) *Introductorius ad magisterium iudiciorum astrorum* (*Kitāb al-Mudḥal ilā ṣinā’at aḥkām*

an-nuġūm), which appeared thirteen times, from the first edition in 1473-1474 to the last in 1521 in Venice" (12). (It must be reiterated, however, that the Arabic astrological corpus, unlike its philosophical or medical counterparts, remained strictly that established by the medieval translation movement, and hence totally insulated against contemporary Arabic developments in the science.)

Yet astrology's boom in popularity among elites also provoked a boom in scholarly and especially humanist critiques. On the one hand, such critiques simply continued long and venerable precedent in pagan, Christian, Islamic and Jewish thought alike, with ancient authors like Cicero and Augustine to medieval giants like Ibn Sīnā, Maimonides and Aquinas attacking the science on grounds variously theological and philosophical. On the other, they reached an unprecedented level of sophistication, contradictoriness and venom in Renaissance scholarship—precisely due to the heavily and irreducibly *Arabic* nature of astrological theory in its Latin reception.

Here the founding book is Giovanni Pico della Mirandola's *Disputationes adversus astrologiam divinatricem*, published posthumously in 1496, which "served as a storehouse of arguments for later critics of astrology" (251). Yet this strident and sweeping attack on the science is ultimately rather self-contradictory. "Some passages criticize the Arabs for deviating from Ptolemy's astrology, other passages criticize the Latins for not knowing their Arabic and Hebrew sources, still others criticize Ptolemaic principles of astrology, but not Ptolemy himself, who is treated respectfully throughout ... While much reads like a rejection of astrology as a whole, other parts seem to advocate a humanist reform that purges Ptolemaic astrology of medieval and Arabic additions" (252). Whatever Pico's intentions were, it is just such a reformist program that was eagerly embraced by many 16th-century astrologers. Thus the Paduan philosopher Agostino Nifo (d. 1538) sneers in his 1505 treatise *De nostrarum calamitatum causis*: "On this topic (*i.e., general astrology*) more recent authors, Albumasar and many others, write much that we consider to be senseless, superstitious and in conflict with philosophy and Ptolemy's theory of the stars.' And he calls Albumasar 'the prince of these fabulists' (*princeps horum fabulantium*)" (*ibid.*). Even more stridently anti-Arabic were Albert Pigghe (d. 1542), a Flemish astrologer-theologian, who explicitly declared war (*bellum*) on what he termed "Punic" fictions and superstitions; Girolamo Cardano (d. 1576), the great Italian astrologer-physician, who attacked the "follies of the Arabs' (*nugas Arabum*)" (253); Tommaso Campanella (d. 1639), apocalypticist *extraordinaire*, who sought to cleanse the science of the "superstition of the Arabs and Jews' (*superstitione Arabum et Judaeorum eliminata*)" (*ibid.*); and Philipp Melanchthon (d. 1560), mastermind of the Reformation, who styled

Saracenic barbarism (*Sarracenic barbaries*) the antithesis and ruinator of Greek astrological wisdom, saved for Europe only by Ptolemy's epitomizing genius.

But pro-Arabic pushback was equally fierce, and here too counterposed against humanist neoclassicizing declinism a progressivist Greek-Arabic-Latin teleology. Thus, for example, the Neopolitan astrologer Giovanni Abioso, who argued *contra* Pico and others that "the Arabs and Saracens perfected what the Greeks were not able to perfect in the sciences," such that "from the doctrine of Ptolemy we can draw much that was written by Messahalāh and Albumasar, who are not in conflict with the wisdom of Ptolemy; rather they by way of consummation and experiment make manifest what Ptolemy has said in truncated and brief manner in the *Tetrabiblos*" (253-54). Indeed, many Renaissance authors went so far as to defend conjunction astrology itself, the invention of Abū Ma'shar, as a doctrine original to, if undeveloped by, Ptolemy.

To determine the extent to which the rhetoric of this declinist vs. progressivist, Greek vs. Arabic controversy actually reflects shifts in the scholarly fortunes of Arabic astrology relative to its Ptolemaic source, Hasse moves beyond such programmatic statements to investigate the technical and nontechnical arguments underpinning them. Because the Renaissance astrological literature is vast and as yet inadequately plumbed, however, he focuses on six topics specific to Arabic astrological theory—interrogations, elections, anniversary horoscopes, calculations of the length of life, lots and revolutions of world years—that emerged as particular foci of dispute, surveying to this end the following representative works: "Pedro Ciruelo's *Apotelesmata* of 1521, a comprehensive handbook of all parts of astrology; Pietro Pitati's *Almanach novum* of 1544, which is representative of the genre of introductions to ephemerides and almanacs; Johannes Schöner's famous summa of natal astrology *De iudiciis libri tres* of 1545; Girolamo Cardano's commentary on Ptolemy's *Tetrabiblos* of 1554, as the best known example of a commentary on Ptolemy; Claude Dariot's *Ad astrorum iudicia facilis introductio* of 1557, an introduction to astrology in humanist style; Francesco Giuntini's *Speculum astrologiae* of 1573, a very influential summa on nativities; and Tommaso Campanella's *Astrologicorum libri VII* of 1614, a comprehensive handbook in the tradition of Ptolemaic reform" (254-55). Hasse then devotes a separate section to the Abū Ma'sharian theory of great conjunctions, "the most prominent object of anti-Arabic polemics" (254).

In sharp contrast to their medieval Latin predecessors, which in arrangement and content hew closely to Arabic models, these seminal Renaissance astrological manuals reflect humanist attempts to subvert scholastic Arabism

to the extent possible; hence sections on interrogations, lots and annual revolutions gradually disappeared from handbooks as terminally post-Greek, and elections not concerning agricultural or medical matters became subject to great skepticism. Yet they also enshrine the primary dilemma of Ptolemaic reformers: “the *Tetrabiblos*, because of its puristic and theoretical character, could not by itself serve as the basis of astrological praxis” (267). Topics of central concern to Renaissance clients, and especially “the prediction of political, religious, and military events” (272), are entirely marginal in Ptolemy, who deals primarily with meteorology and agriculture. Thus even such outspokenly anti-Arabic astrologers as Cardano, Schöner and Giuntini continued, two-facedly, to write treatises on or include discussions of Arabic topics they elsewhere reject on theoretical grounds.

Renaissance astrology, in short, appears to be characterized by an unprecedented gap between theory and praxis. And even on the level of theory, “many Arabic traditions continue to thrive in spite of the criticism voiced against them by advocates of a return to Ptolemy: elections remain a standard chapter in astrological handbooks, as do anniversary horoscopes and the Alcocoden theory. Anniversary horoscopes, in fact, far from being suppressed, gain a popularity in sixteenth-century astrological literature that is unparalleled in the centuries before, in spite of the attempts to revive Ptolemaic methods of prorogation. Nor did humanist attacks prevent the conjunctionist theory of history, which is lacking any Greek credentials, from becoming extraordinarily successful in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries” (290). That the latter so strikingly flourished, moreover, was due not only to the fact that “it was supported by trends in chronology and Christian views of history but also because its astronomical basis was transformed successfully by Renaissance astrologers, so that it became much more easily applicable to history” (291).

“In sum, there is much reason to believe that the Arabic traditions in Renaissance astrology developed as they did not only for reasons of context but also for reasons internal to the science” (ibid.). On the one hand, the humanist partisanship for Ptolemy against “the Arabs” did trigger transformations that were productive in purely scientific terms, for it forced Renaissance astrologers to reflect closely on the theoretical validity of the astrological doctrines then current, and in some cases even produce models of greater technical precision. On the other, widespread social demand for specifically Arabic operations seems to have made hypocrites of certain Ptolemaic reformers, who found themselves unable, despite considerable effort, to avoid a measure of Arabic partisanship in practical and even occasionally theoretical matters; thus “the expectations of Renaissance clients also played a conservative role in the development of astrological theory” (292).

Success vs. Suppression, Ideology vs. Science

For all its bluster, the humanist anti-Arabism that so defined Renaissance scholarship was thus rarely able to realize its purificationist *ad fontes* ideal due to the simple inadequacy of Greek sources for sustaining the full range of early modern Western intellection, and its victories were always partial: Latin Arabism (and Hebraism) remained inescapable. The countervailing success of Arabism became most notably entrenched in university curricula, and indeed sparked a *philological revolution* emblemized by the new Arabic-Hebrew-Latin translation movement. At the same time, humanist ideology did often succeed in reforming individual sciences through the purging, suppressing or camouflaging of Arabic “accretions”—if usually only at the level of theory, not of praxis.

But the humanist ideological program was decidedly a mixed bag in scientific terms: “Renaissance opposition to Arabic traditions in philosophy and the sciences was motivated by an amalgam of scientific arguments, mere partisanship, and outright ideology” (311). It led to increased theoretical and technical rigor in many fields, to be sure, but also produced bad or useless science, and worse philology; and the Western intellectual histories produced in the Renaissance were flatly *fantastical*. Most debilitatingly, it enforced the total intellectual insulation of Latin scholarship against contemporary Arabic developments. Even the philological labors of such masterful translators as the Venetian physician Alpago, who actually and exceptionally sought out new Arabic manuscripts in the Levant, remained trained solely on those medieval Arabic texts in vogue in Europe; and even progressivist, pro-Arabist scholars pushed a Greek-Arabic-Latin supersessionist teleology. That is to say: the humanist quest to return to the pure and ancient sources of European wisdom utterly failed to draw down the flood of Arabic texts and Arabic learning in Europe—yet dammed that flood so utterly that it remained forever *medieval*.

It is especially, even painfully, ironic, then, that Renaissance scholarship is only very rarely *orientalizing*; if anything, authors and bio-bibliographers are keen to occidentalize the Arabic sources on which they are so dependent. Such burgeoning *eurocentrism*, the natural upshot of humanist neoclassicism, and expressed by the forcible hellen- or hispanization of those Arabic authorities who proved theoretically and practically indispensable, served most notably to sever all association of Arabic learning with the Ottoman Empire, “the main object of the imagination of the Orient in the Renaissance” (307). This rupture would be dramatically reversed only in the 17th century, when orientalization, and hence orientalism, became rampant in Europe.

Hasse's study forcefully and successfully sidesteps the claims of humanist and orientalist scholarship alike to return us to the textual genesis of these eurocentrizing ideologies in the 15th and 16th centuries. The fruits of his philological labors are on full display in the Conclusion, which incisively plots Hasse's findings along the two axes that have served to structure his study as a whole: success vs. suppression, ideology vs. science. (Here he defines suppression as "conscious opposition to scientific theories for nonscientific reasons" [300].) In reviewing each of his case studies in these analytical terms, Hasse shows humanist ideology to have been simultaneously scientifically productive and retrograde.

Indeed, the profound ideological-scientific *mixedness* of Renaissance humanist scholarship sometimes produced outright paradox. Pico della Mirandola himself stands as incarnation of precisely this Renaissance paradox: he promoted the success of Arabism in his status as aristocratic patron of a new and crucial Averroes translation, and in his pan-concordist *Conclusiones* he vaunts "the Arabs" as a major source of the *prisca sapientia*—heavily occult-scientific and Abrahamic—to which Latin Christians must return; yet his seminal critique of the preeminent occult science that is astrology is driven by a patent anti-Arabism. Renaissance humanists, it would seem, often endeavored to have their anti-Arabist cake and eat it too.

As that may be, "the Renaissance opposition to and suppression of Arabic sciences and philosophy took place mainly for European reasons, not for Oriental ones. Humanists opposed Arabic traditions because they entertained strong beliefs about antiquity, not because they entertained strong beliefs about Arabic or Islamic culture" (314). Nevertheless, "Renaissance humanists are the inventors of cultural clichés that persist even today—that Arabic science amounts to plagiarism; that it is nothing more than Greek thought in Arabic garb; that the Arabs were mere transmitters of science from antiquity to medieval Europe; in other words, as Epicurus is said to have claimed, that 'only Greeks are able to philosophize'" (ibid.). "Today, we all too readily believe that it is the West by itself that in the seventeenth century developed a dynamic unparalleled in history. One source of this belief is the very fact that, in the Renaissance, humanist hard-liners had largely erased the contribution of Arabic science to European culture. They worked on a purist construction of the Western tradition as essentially Greek, and, at best, also Roman and Christian" (ibid.). But as Hasse's study shows in exhaustive philological detail, it is strictly modern colonialist hindsight that has awarded such humanist anti-Arabism unqualified victory; its exponents hardly enjoyed hegemonic influence during their own lifetimes, and were frequently and ably countered by their pro-Arabist peers. "Many medieval and many Renaissance scholars

knew better and were fully aware that Arabic scholars, too, are able to philosophize” (315).

Taḥqīqism as Early Modernity

In this glorious and felicitated era ... the decree of the world's sovereign [i.e., Emperor Akbar] has been universally effected, to wit, that all administrators of the empire, regardless of rank, who glory in the continuous and indeed ever-increasing royal grace shown them, are to know that once the entirety of their exalted purpose has achieved the fulfillment of the hopes and dreams of the totality of humanity, their sacred charge, putting wholly at ease elite and commoner alike, they are to turn their peerless attention to divine pursuits. Having freed, that is, the neck of their doctrine from the chain of imitation—repudiated by the prophet-leaders of every nation and people, its flagrant and corrupting effects denounced in every religion in the most vivid of terms—, they are to seek rather the means of verification. They are to pursue no universal or particular objective, down to the most minor, save by way of demonstrative proof and conclusive argument, and their perspicacious, perfecting minds, inspired by divine effluxion and occult guidance and aid in accordance with the sublimest of principles, are to continually consider scientific truths and philosophical complexities. Thus shall their sound opinion on each subject preserve and continue that laid down by the ancients and the moderns....

MUGHAL ROYAL DECREE EFFECTING THE ILĀHĪ CALENDAR (1584)⁴

4 A transcript of Akbar's royal decree—which, strikingly, places great emphasis on the need to create a new, more scientifically accurate calendar appropriate to a new imperial era, critiquing Hindu and Islamic calendars in equal measure—is preserved in 'Alī Muḥammad Khān's (fl. 1761) *Mir'āt-i Aḥmadī*, ed. Syed Nawab Ali, 2 vols. (Baroda: Oriental Institute, 1928-30), 1/159-63; my thanks to Daniel Sheffield for this reference. The quote above translates its remarkable opening statement (159): *darīn zamān-i dawlat-ārāy u hangām-i sa'ādat-pīrā'ī ... farmān-i gītī-muṭā' partav-i irtifā' yāft ki hukkām-i maḥrūsa u sāyir-i mutaṣaddiyān-i mahammāt-i māli u mulki bi taṣāvut-i darajāt u tanāsub-i ṭabaqāt bi tavātūr u takāṣur-i makārim-i shāhanshāhī muftakhir u mustaḥsir būda bi-dānand ki chūn tamāmī-yi himmat-i vālā maṣrūf-i ān ast ki kāffa-yi anām az khavāṣṣ u 'avāmm ki badāyī'-i vadāyī'-i ghaybī-and dar ḡilāl-i amānī u āmāl munshariḥ al-bāl u mu'arrafat al-ḥāl būda awqāt-i garāmī-rā ki maṣḡūd al-badal u ma'dūm al-'avaż-ast dar marḡbiyyāt-i ilāhī maṣrūf dārand va raqaba-yi 'aqīdat-i khūd-rā az qilāda-yi taqlīd ki arbāb-i milāl kulluhum u aṣḥāb-i niḥal qjma'uhum dast-rū bar ān zada-and va dar jamī'-i adyān ma'āṣir-i qabāḥat u vaqāḥat-i ān*

As *Success and Suppression* establishes, Renaissance scholars performed thoroughgoing *taḥqīq* on and called for various degrees of *taqlīd* of their Greco-Arabic intellectual patrimony, critiquing, refining, rejecting, subverting, translating, editing, collating, compiling, demonizing, championing. What Hasse declines to acknowledge, however, is the fact that remarkably similar philosophical-philological projects were being pursued across the contemporary Afro-Eurasian ecumene as a whole. Indeed, in their cognate departures from or transformations of medieval and classical precedent and their use of cognate philological methodologies to this end, such projects together constitute, many philologists are now arguing, a new epistemic style that is distinctively *early modern*. Their striking similarities aside, moreover, culturally distinct modes of philosophical-philological discourse, sustained by textual sources often radically different, could not but be epistemologically divergent; these modes therefore constitute in turn *alternate early modernities*.

Just such a new framework for the study of these textual early modernities, Western or otherwise, has now been proposed in *World Philology*.⁵ Edited by Sheldon Pollock, Benjamin Elman and Ku-ming Kevin Chang, this groundbreaking collection of essays surveys, in some cases for the first time, the *philological revolutions* that swept the Afro-Eurasian ecumene from the 9th century to the 19th, with that of the European Renaissance being but one instance among many. Pollock opens the volume thusly (1):

[A] number of us have become increasingly intrigued by the hypothesis that an early modern transformation in philology may be detectable across much of the world.... This may have begun, according to our still

bi ablagh-i vujūh adā mī-nimāyand bāz-dāshta dar taḥṣīl-i asbāb-i taḥqīq ma'tūf gardānand va dar masālik-i maṭālib-i kullīyya u juzvīyya bī-badraqa-yi dalīl qadam na-nihand va dar [mashāri'-i] maqāṣid-i khūd nafīr^{an} u qītmīr^{an} bī-izā'at-i ḥujjat shurū' na-nimāyand va ḡamīr-i iṣābat-pazīr-i mā istikmāl^{an} u takmīl^{an} hamvāra dar ḥaqāyiq-i 'ilmī u daqāyiq-i ḥikmī naẓar mī-andāzand va bi 'ināyāt u hidāyāt-i ghaybī az mabādī-yi 'āliya bi vasīla-yi ilhāmāt u vāridāt mustafīd u mustafīz-ast va az āṣār-i salaf u khalaf nīz bi muqtaẓā-yi ḥusn-i sarīrat u ṣafā'ī-yi 'aqīdat maḥfūz u bahra-mand.

- 5 Pollock's introduction to *World Philology* expands upon his earlier programmatic essay "Future Philology? The Fate of a Soft Science in a Hard World," *Critical Inquiry* 35/4 (2009): 931-61. A similar program is proposed and more broadly pursued in the present journal, edited by Islam Dayeh, who summarizes the findings and achievements to date of his Berlin-based research program "Zukunftphilologie: Revisiting the Canons of Textual Scholarship" in an article in the journal's inaugural issue ("The Potential of World Philology," *Philological Encounters* 1 (2016): 396-418); the same issue includes two other essays, by Pollock and Rajeev Kinra respectively, that similarly constitute the immediate context for my arguments below.

provisional hypothesis, as early as the first quarter of the second millennium; it is in full view almost everywhere by the seventeenth century, when scholars like Benedict de Spinoza in Europe, Melpputūr Nārāyaṇa Bhaṭṭatīri in India, and Yan Ruojū in China sought actively to transform philological thinking.

The case studies that follow, necessarily eclectic and uneven given the undeveloped state of many of the relevant fields, and ranging temporally from ancient Greece to modern China and geographically from western Europe to Japan, offer not a little substantiation for this hypothesis, and together issue a rousing call to flesh out this new narrative of Afro-Eurasian early modernity with many further such studies.

Added thereto, Hasse's exhaustive study of Renaissance Arabist philology thus takes on a much broader significance. For it traces but one of the many trajectories of *early modern Arabism*—most of which, naturally, belonged rather to the *Islamicate* world, and all of which diverged and converged in instructive, even surprising, ways. The burgeoning of these Arabisms, in turn, seems to have been but a subset of a much larger world-historical process defining early modern Afro-Eurasian intellectual history as a whole. Both points are hinted at in two *World Philology* essays in particular: Khaled El-Rouayheb on the rise of “deep reading” among early modern Ottoman scholarly elites (ch. 9), and Muzaffar Alam on the production of a Mughal edition of Rūmī's *Maṣnavī* (ch. 8). I will make explicit what is there left implicit by invoking several other recent or forthcoming studies with which *Success and Suppression* and *World Philology* are best read in tandem.

In his essay, El-Rouayheb documents the emergence of a new scholarly relationship to the book in the 17th-18th-century Ottoman context: breaking with Islamicate precedent, which long consistently, if increasingly rhetorically, valorized orality over textuality in the transmission of knowledge and the assertion of scholarly authority, Ottoman intellectuals began to vaunt books as standalone sources of knowledge.⁶ This cultural shift, this philological turn, is encapsulated in the new genre of *ādāb al-muṭālaʿa*, the proper manner of reading, works on which first began appearing in the 17th century; it culminated in the unprecedented depersonalization and institutionalization of Islamicate

6 Along very different, occult-philosophical lines, I argue for the theoretical displacement of orality by textuality already in early Timurid Iran as fitting preface to and impetus for the burgeoning of book and visual culture so definitive of the early modern Persianate world more broadly (“Of Islamic Grammarology: Ibn Turka's Lettrist Metaphysics of Light,” *al-ʿUṣūr al-Wuṣṭā* 24 (2016): 42-113).

education peculiar to the Ottoman context. Yet Ottoman scholars were no *humanists*, in the technical, Renaissance sense of that term; that is to say, they were not neoclassicizing declinists. El-Rouayheb here offers an intriguing pan-Eurasian comparison (222-23):

The philological techniques and aims of European humanists, as well as seventeenth- and eighteenth-century Chinese “evidentiary” scholars, ... were intimately linked to the rejection of the immediate past and the attempted recovery of the texts of an earlier and preferred age. There is little evidence for such a concern among Ottoman scholars of the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries.

Rather, the latter gloried in their connection to—their paradoxically *taḥqīqī taqlīd* of—the immediate and specifically Timurid-Turkmen-Mamluk scholarly past, and were content to textually inherit the ancients through that well-burnished prism.

This chapter constitutes a teaser for El-Rouayheb’s larger, masterful study *Islamic Intellectual History in the Seventeenth Century: Scholarly Currents in the Ottoman Empire and the Maghreb* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2015)—the first, and hence necessarily preliminary, attempt at a synthetic Ottoman intellectual history from the 16th to 18th centuries. Where Hasse takes as case studies the fields of metaphysics, medicine-pharmacology and astrology, El-Rouayheb focuses rather on Ottoman reading practices as applied to logic, dialectics, theology and sufism. (Problematically, he largely ignores works in Persian; it should be emphasized, however, that Ottoman scholarship remained strongly Perso-Arabic and iranocentric, even after the emergence of Ottoman Turkish as an imperial-literary language.) As he shows, the Ottoman Empire and neighboring Islamicate realms saw a boom in the study of the rational sciences—a boom nurtured, as in contemporary Renaissance Europe, by the emergence of new textual-philological methodologies and modes of argumentation, both going under the rubric of *taḥqīq*. Crucially, El-Rouayheb dismisses altogether the categories of *humanism* and *enlightenment* as too terminally eurocentric to be usefully applied to early modern Islamicate developments. Equally crucially, he rejects the extreme colonialist-reformist reduction of Islam to scripturalism and legalism, which protestantizing reduction is enshrined in orientalist scholarship: of the little that exists on early modern Islamicate intellectual history, the majority is concerned strictly with Islamic law, and particularly with debates as to the possibility of *ijtihād*, or independent legal reasoning, in the “postclassical” era. El-Rouayheb accordingly counterposes the term *taḥqīq*, independent verification, as

far more broadly indicative of the intellectual culture of the early modern Islamicate heartlands—and in permanent, paradoxical, aporetic tension with *taqlīd*.⁷

Precisely the same binary, Hasse's findings indicate, shaped contemporary Christianate philology and philosophy-science; but it did so on a differing textual base, and so had very different results. Yet the two scholarly cultures' shared, if proportionally modest, Arabic core suggests points of possible convergence as well. I therefore propose *taḥqīq* and *taqlīd* as terms more appropriate—because less ideologically-teleologically charged, at least in English—to the comparative study of early modern Arabisms as a genetic unit, from those of the Latinate world to those of the Persianate, all of which were scene to pitched contests between *declinist neoclassicists* on the one hand and *progressivist supersessionists* on the other. Modern teleologies aside, we have seen for the Renaissance context that the victory claimed by the first faction, flying the banner of humanism, was decidedly partial, and far more rhetorical than actual: Arabism remained a primary motor of Latinate scholarship through the 17th century. How, then, did the same contest resolve in Arabism's many Islamicate and especially Persianate trajectories?

The extent to which Ottoman Arabism, for example, textually diverged from or converged with that embraced by Renaissance scholars is as yet unmappable due to a total absence, El-Rouayheb's preliminary offering aside, of similarly targeted and philologically rigorous studies drawing on the more massive Ottoman archive. And even his necessarily neglects those fields most susceptible of direct comparison to Renaissance Arabist-humanist developments (not that the latter should be used to measure the former); this includes in the first place metaphysics on the one hand and the occult sciences on the other.

The example of astrology is here again representative. Where Hasse can build on over a century of scholarship on this science in its Renaissance iterations, yet still complain of major lacunae, the *first* closely textual study of Ottoman astrology was carried out *only in 2016*, and that in the form of an as yet unpublished University of Chicago dissertation: A. Tunç Şen's "Astrology in the Service of the Empire: Knowledge, Prognostication, and Politics at

7 Edward Said—no Islamicist—rather suggests *ijtihād*, which he fancifully translates as "close reading," as the core principle of "Arab" philology ("The Return to Philology," in idem, *Humanism and Democratic Criticism* [New York: Columbia University Press, 2004], 57-84, esp. 75).

the Ottoman Court, 1450s-1550s.”⁸ Although it is far too early to venture Renaissance-Ottoman comparisons in this field, as in all others, Şen’s findings nevertheless suggest that Ottoman astrology too was scene to and impetus for significant scientific advances, and particularly an increased emphasis on observational enterprises and the technical refinement of celestial data. Just as obtained in the Renaissance context slightly to the west, “the urge to practice a mathematically precise and scientifically valid astrology was closely linked to the contemporary renaissance of mathematics and astronomical instrumentation in the eastern Islamic lands” (29)—hence the unprecedented, and unparalleled, institutionalization of the science at the Ottoman court.

At the same time, Ottoman astrologers, like their Renaissance Arabist peers, often had to contend with ideological opposition, which pushed the debate in specific directions variously theoretically productive and unproductive. But those directions naturally differed, for the ideological pressures were different: only Renaissance astrology, equally heavily Arabic and founded on many of the same classical sources, was subjected to the anti-Arabism of neoclassicizing humanists. The latter nevertheless discovered, of course, to their chagrin, that any quest for a purely Ptolemaic astrology must be quixotic; but their reforms of Greco-Arabo-Latin astrology shaped the science’s theory and practice for centuries in ways that were limited to western Europe. In the Ottoman context, by contrast, the primary sticking point was not chauvinist but theological: astrologers were obliged to parry constant accusations of astral determinism.⁹ As a consequence, the majority of astrologers serving the Ottoman court were openly critical of the epistemological limitations of their discipline. The rhetorical focus of courtly Ottoman astrological literature was not millenarian, messianic and apocalyptic, Şen argues, as has usually been assumed (given the endemicity of these currents to the Mediterranean zone), but rather on the theme of *divine cosmic order*—as mirrored and performed by the Ottoman sovereign. Most religious scholars accordingly permitted the practice of this scientifically and theologically sober brand of imperial Arabo-Persian astrology, and a few even eagerly mastered the science themselves; it was rather prominent *sufis* who mounted the severest opposition thereto—a social feature that would appear to be unique to the Ottoman context. Such

8 Mughal astrology too has also been almost totally neglected, apart from the work of Eva Orthmann in particular; the history of Safavid astrology remains entirely unwritten.

9 This is not to suggest that Renaissance humanist neoclassicism as applied to astrology was less profoundly shaped by theological concerns of a similar stripe, but rather that such concerns were there paired with open chauvinism in a manner wholly absent, naturally, from contemporary Ottoman scholarship.

Islam-Christian divergences notwithstanding, however, the early modern era was indeed the golden age of astrology, in Renaissance Europe as in the Ottoman, Safavid and Mughal Empires. But where the imperial astrologers of the former were often declinist and chauvinist, the latter—and here we may safely assume the Ottoman case to be representative of broader Persianate developments—were as a rule progressivist and cosmopolitan, sedately building on, expanding and correcting Ilkhanid-Timurid Iranian textual models in particular.

What of Mughal philology? Which faction, if any, won the contest in India? That it was similarly carried by the progressivists is suggested by Alam's case study in *World Philology*. Treating of 'Abd al-Laṭīf 'Abbāsī Gujarātī's (d. 1638) remarkable critical edition of the *Maṣnavī-yi Ma'navī*—a 13th-century multivolume mystical-poetical masterpiece widely beloved as the "Persian Quran"—, here Alam closely focuses on the editorial techniques this Mughal scholar deployed to accomplish his philological objective: *muqābala*, *taṣḥīḥ* and *tanqīḥ*, or collation, correction and purgation. As he shows, these techniques had venerable precedent in Arabic scholarship, to be sure; but their more rigorous and systematic use in the Mughal context, not to mention the Ottoman, may be said to represent a new philological turn. The Persianate world, and particularly its South Asian subset, saw a boom in lexicography and literary criticism specifically and philology generally from the 16th to 18th centuries—well before the intermeddling of British colonialist scholars.

This boom, Alam notes, is epitomized by the philological labors of Sirāj al-Dīn 'Alī Khān (d. 1756), penname Ārzū, admired poet in Persian and Urdu and important theoretician of language. As is par for the early modern Islamicate and especially Persianate course, only one monograph has been devoted to this major figure to date, and that a similarly recent and as yet unpublished doctoral dissertation: Arthur Dudley's "A Desire for Meaning: Khān-i Ārzū's Philology and the Place of India in the Eighteenth-Century Persianate World" (Columbia University, 2013).¹⁰ Significantly for our purposes here, Dudley suggests the Quarrel of the Ancients and the Moderns, so definitive of early modern European literary-scholarly culture, to be equally definitive of early modern Persian, with the 15th century serving as pivot. This quarrel was resolved after the fact in favor of the champions of the Ancients, to wit, the Iranian exponents of the 18th-century neoclassicizing movement termed in the 20th the *bāzgasht-i adabī* ('literary return'). Initially partial and decidedly local, their victory was effectively totalized in the late 19th and early

10 See also his "Metaphorical Language as a Battleground for Tradition and Newness in Late Mughal Persian," *International Journal of Persian Literature* 2 (2017): 138-60.

20th centuries in colonialist-nationalist discourse, which served to demonize the Moderns and divorce Iran from India; like Renaissance humanists before them, these “returners” finally, though only posthumously, succeeded in writing the immediate poetical past out of Persian literary history by recasting it as rampantly baroque and suspiciously alien (i.e., Indian) and hence culturally terminally decadent—in short, as irredeemably *postclassical*.¹¹ (It is no accident that the same period saw the gradual burgeoning among Muslim intellectuals of *salafism*, a radically declinist ideology equally hostile to the immediate Islamic past.¹²)

But during the early modern Indo-Persianate moment itself, it was precisely the declinists who lost, and lost badly: Safavid-Mughal poetry is defined by the Fresh Style (*tarz-i tāza*), aka Newspeak (*tāza-gūʾī*), terms expressive of a boldly modernizing ethos. Yet its exponents—not unlike many of their contemporary Arabist peers in Europe—still remained faithful to immediate precedent, which they simply transmogrified and extended in unprecedented ways. Dudney thus usefully defines this peculiarly early modern scholarly-literary sensibility as “maintain[ing] a tremendous respect for tradition while stretching that tradition’s fundamental assumptions to the breaking point and sometimes beyond” (311). Ārzū himself was the first scholar to mount a rigorous theoretical-historical defense of Newspeak—with *taḥqīq* here too, not surprisingly, being the salient Arabo-Persian term of art.

11 So completely did they succeed, indeed, that Persianists are only now beginning the process of retrieving major figures, including Indo-Persian poets like Ṣāʾib (d. 1676), an author of Shakespearean significance, whose work was yet influential over a geographical and cultural spread far vaster than that of Shakespeare; Paul Losensky is here leading the charge.

At the same time, it must be emphasized that the Ancient and Modern poetical camps were far from stable, and varied regionally and indeed from scholar to scholar; there were likewise many early modern defenders of the style of the Ancients in India, for example, and even bold Newspeakers like Bābā Fighānī Shīrāzī (d. 1519) were recast as Ancients in the 18th century (my thanks to Mana Kia for this observation; for an account and critique of the anachronistic nationalization of this perennial aesthetic debate, see her forthcoming *Sensibilities of Belonging: Transregional Persianate Community before Nationalism*, ch. 4).

12 It is here significant that this burgeoning of salafism—the typically anti-Ottoman doctrine of Ibn ʿAbd al-Wahhāb (d. 1792) excepted—often took place under the auspices of sufism. On this alliance see Ahmad Dallal’s forthcoming *Islam without Europe: Traditions of Reform in Eighteenth-Century Islamic Thought* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2018); my thanks to Islam Dayeh for this reference.

Early modern Persian literary-scholarly practice, in short, openly pursuing *modernness*, diverged broadly and gorgeously from its medieval Arabo-Persian parent, just as European literary-scholarly vernaculars did from their Greco-Latin. And in the process, indeed, New Persian ultimately outstripped Arabic—like New English was to do Christianate Latin—as preeminent Islamicate language of *universal empire*.¹³ Thus imperialized and universalized, it became the birthing ground for an empiricist *comparative philology* that was distinctively, consciously modern, particularly in the radically cosmopolitan Indo-Persianate context. Yet here the palm has long been awarded solely to Sir William Jones (d. 1794), that Copernicus of history, that founder of the modern human and social sciences—who in the late 19th century was charged with attempting, in classic colonialist-orientalist fashion, to hide his debt to the colonized natives, and Ārzū in particular: the latter first proposed his (less explicit) comparative theory of the concomitance of Persian and Sanskrit (*tavāfuq-i lisānayn*) several decades before Jones was to do the same, as the latter may have known. Dudney rightly cautions us against snap judgments as to intellectual theft in this case, however, suggesting intellectual parallelism as a likelier, and equally striking, possibility (123–30). But the principle holds: modernity—including modern philology—was not *something done to a supine Asia* by colonialist operatives like Jones; rather, it was everywhere co-produced and dizzyingly multiple.

Triumphalist Enlightenment declinism, of course, fanatically obsessed with cultural rupture, held and holds all such continuities, connections and co-productions anathema, and so its devotees have assiduously, violently, *philologically* rendered them historically illegible: for Enlightenment requires the *endarkenment* of all Others. (If Western early modernity was the golden age of philosophical-philological progressivism, Western modernity is the golden age of golden-ageist declinism.) To write a more evenhanded, *twilit* history of

13 This outstripping, however, was confined to the imperial mode, whereby New Persian (and the heavily Persianate Ottoman Turkish) displaced Arabic as preeminent language of Islamicate government in the Balkans-to-Bengal complex—while still emulating, extending and transforming its classical Arabic models. Controversies over the rise of vernaculars were peculiar to western Europe, far less imperially integrated, where English, German, Dutch, French, Italian, Spanish and Portuguese ultimately disassembled the Latin cosmopolis by the 18th century; in sharp contrast, the Persian cosmopolis remained intact and indeed vibrant to the early 20th century (with Urdu and various forms of Turkic as its major subsets), and the Arabic to the present. On this cosmopolitan-vernacular tension across the Afro-Eurasian ecumene, and for a critique and refinement of Pollock's concept of the cosmopolis as applied to its Sanskrit instance, see Alexander Beecroft, *An Ecology of World Literature: From Antiquity to the Present Day* (London: Verso, 2015).

the myriad ruptures and continuities that constitute early modernity, in the Indo-Persianate world as elsewhere, we modern Western philologists must more loudly recant the Endarkening, self-blinkering declinism of Jones's modern heirs (captive members, like him, of the cult of origins and originality, for whom any ethnoreligious ambiguity or intellectual incrementalism is anathema),¹⁴ must more convincingly abjure the equally parochial chauvinism of Ārzū's protonationalist scholarly foes (who sought to render the ebullience and experimentalism of Indo-Persian literary-philological culture, consciously modernizing, mere alien decadence), in favor of an Ārzuvian progressivist, cosmopolitan *tahqīq* that celebrates continuity and sees it.¹⁵

Such Mughal-British scholarly continuities aside, the feature of Mughal philology most strikingly comparable to its contemporary European cognate is also the point at which the two textually diverge most sharply: the Sanskrit-Persian translation movement, no less epochal than the Renaissance Arabic-Hebrew-Latin, and like it unparalleled in the early modern Afro-Eurasian context.¹⁶ Where the latter merely produced new translations of already popular medieval authorities like Ibn Rushd, however, the former rendered into Persian such central Sanskrit classics as the *Mahābhārata*, *Rāmāyaṇa* and *Upaniṣads* for the first time; and Mughal imperial patronage pushed Brahman and Jain Sanskrit literature in new directions in turn. As such, it constitutes a signal *joint* victory for the forces of neoclassicism and

14 Here Jones's fusion of language and ethnic identity—running violently counter to Ārzū's separation and ambiguation of precisely the same—was especially pernicious; its modern upshot, of course, is nationalism, Aryan supremacism and antisemitism, which is to say the very concept of *race*, with emphasis on preserving its *purity*—the ultimate in declinist-taqlidist ideologizing. On the existential threat the early modern orientalist philological revolution posed to “Europeanness” as a category, and the development by European scholars of a neat Hellenism vs. Hebraism, then Aryan vs. Semitic, binary in reaction thereto, see Tomoko Masuzawa, *The Invention of World Religions: Or, How European Universalism Was Preserved in the Language of Pluralism* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2005), chh. 5 and 6.

15 Seconding and broadening Dudley's call, Rajeev Kinra (“Cultures of Comparative Philology in the Early Modern Indo-Persian World,” *Philological Encounters* 1 (2016): 225–87) suggests that any discussion of emergent modernity and modern historical linguistics that excludes the massive, still almost wholly unexplored (Indo-)Persian philological corpus—as the vast majority of such discussions have to date—must be dismissed as simply abortive.

16 If the Greek, Syriac and Persian-to-Arabic translation movement under the Abbasids marks the end and apotheosis of late antiquity, this renewed enthusiasm for translation from India to Italy some six centuries later would seem to mark the advent of Western early modernity (or modernities).

modernism, of *taḥqīq*-and-*taqlīd*, whose productive tension here proved remarkably culturally transformative.¹⁷

For all its epochal importance, however, the first philologically and historically competent study of this translation movement is yet again a very recent one: Audrey Truschke's *Culture of Encounters: Sanskrit at the Mughal Court* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2016). As exhaustively detailed by Truschke (like Dudney, a student, not incidentally, of Pollock), the same *taḥqīq*ist ethos was nurtured and sharpened by this Sanskrito-Persian philological bonanza; indeed, in certain instances it was *imperially weaponized* as antidote to Islamic scholarly *taqlīd*ism. Wonderfully illustrative of this imperial *taḥqīq*ist-*taqlīd*ist tension is the fact that Emperor Akbar (r. 1556-1605) himself—*talismanic-astrocratic Lord of Conjunction*¹⁸ and divine philosopher-king, whose decree, as seen in the epigraph above, quite literally made scientific-spiritual *taḥqīq* the law of the land—wielded the newly Persianized *Mahābhārata* against the standard young-earth doctrine pushed by Muslim and Christian divines at his (in)famous House of Worship (*ʿibādat-khāna*), arguing instead for “the antiquity of the universe and its beings” (128-30).

The Mughal Sanskrit-Persian translation movement thus served to *orientalize* the Persian cosmopolis—but also to *occidentalize* the Sanskrit. As with the reception of Arabic authors in Renaissance Europe, certain Sanskrit classics were subject to a strong Westernizing impulse. Perhaps the most notable example of this is the now much celebrated Persian translation of the *Upaniṣads* by Emperor Shāhjahān's son and would-be successor Dārā Shukūh (d. 1659), the *Supreme Secret* (*Sirr-i Akbar*), completed in 1657. Herein the Mughal saint-prince seeks to excavate the strictly monotheistic core of Hindu

17 The same Mughal brand of paradoxically modernizing neoclassicism likewise drove the early modern emergence of Hindi as a major literary-imperial language; see Allison Busch, “The Anxiety of Innovation: The Practice of Literary Science in the Hindi/*Rīti* Tradition,” *Comparative Studies of South Asia, Africa and the Middle East* 24/2 (2004): 45-59.

18 In the post-Mongol Persianate imperial context, the royal title Lord of Conjunction (*ṣāhib-qirān*), based solely on the conjunction astrology of Abū Maʿshar and signifying Alexandrian-Mongol-Timurid world conquest, far outstripped in importance such classical Islamicate titles as caliph and sultan; see Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “Early Modern Islamicate Empire: New Forms of Religiopolitical Legitimacy,” in *The Wiley-Blackwell History of Islam*, ed. Armando Salvatore et al. (Malden [MASS]: Wiley-Blackwell, 2018), 353-75. By contrast, Abū Maʿsharian conjunction astrology, its legitimacy partially undermined by Renaissance humanist scholars, as shown by Hasse, never achieved the same political hegemony in a much imperially weaker early modern Latinate Europe—a divergence that suggests the uniquely Arabic science as a major node for comparative Islamo-Christianate historiography going forward.

doctrine, and to this end makes a remarkable and wholly unprecedented argument for the status of this Sanskrit scripture as the quranic *kitāb makhnūn* (Q 56:77-80), the primordial 'hidden book' expounding exhaustively what the Quran thus need only summarize. That is to say: the Arabic scripture, highly streamlined and *modern*, can only be fully understood with reference to the ancient and unabridged *Upaniṣads*. Such a concordist argument, of course, epitomizes the historical function of the Persian cosmopolis as fructifying marriage bed of East and West. But it should be noted that the cultural current here still flows powerfully westward/Westward, toward the heartlands of Islam: for Dārā Shukūh vaunts his eastern classic—by recasting it in terms overtly *Hellenic-Abrahamic*.¹⁹

This is not to say that remarkable parallels did not obtain between the Persian and Sanskrit cosmopolises beyond the Mughal imperial sphere that married them; contemporary literary-scholarly developments in South India likewise express a new, distinctively early modern ethos whose philosophical-philological similarities to specifically Islamicate developments—presumably in the absence of direct contact—are rather astounding. Here David Shulman's *More than Real: A History of the Imagination in South India* (Cambridge [MASS]: Harvard University Press, 2012) offers a crucial and highly suggestive intervention. As this magnificent study establishes, from the 15th century onward the cultural and textual landscape of southern India was transformed by a veritable conceptual revolution, one pivoting on the category of *imagination* as autonomous and supreme human faculty, indeed the defining feature of *humanness*. He posits it as "part of a much greater civilizational shift, a Renaissance-like reimagining of human life in all major domains together with radical experimentation in the forms and modes of political and economic life" (281-82).²⁰ Yet the most intriguing comparison Shulman draws is not with Latinate Europe—where imagination was hailed as not therapeutic but *pathological*—, but rather with the strikingly similar doctrine of the Andalusian sage Ibn 'Arabī (d. 1240), which had become utterly hegemonic throughout

19 For a fuller discussion of the *Sirr-i Akbar*, see Supriya Gandhi, "Mughal Self-Fashioning, Indic Self-Realization: Dārā Shikoh and Persian Textual Cultures in Early Modern South Asia" (PhD diss., Harvard University, 2011), ch. 4.

20 Jonardon Ganeri's similarly pioneering study *The Lost Age of Reason: Philosophy in Early Modern India 1450-1700* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011) also requires mention in this context. Treating more strictly of Sanskrit philosophy, it too traces conceptual and methodological seachanges wrought by South Indian thinkers as constituting a new, early modern ethos: "Openness to inquiry into the problems themselves, a turn toward the facts, is what drives the new work, not merely a new exegesis of the ancient texts, along with a sense that they are engaged in a radical and ongoing project" (5).

the Persianate world by the 15th century. Early modern Islamic philosophy, quite simply, is heavily, irreducibly Ibn ‘Arabian, and hence similarly prized imagination as the chiefest means of transcending mere reason to achieve human divinization, *theosis* (*ta‘alluh*). The same doctrine was increasingly eagerly seized upon by post-Mongol Muslim dynasts—many of them self-divinizing saint-kings—as a basis for universalist-millenarian imperial claims; that is to say, Timurid, Mughal, Safavid and Ottoman imperialisms were in their formative phase expressly Ibn ‘Arabian.²¹

Perhaps we may speak, then, El-Rouayheb’s legitimate concerns notwithstanding, of a common *Islamic-Indic humanism*;²² and if so, it was surely at least as definitive of early modernity as its far more ideologically narrow, strictly declinist Renaissance namesake. For it encompassed a much larger percentage of the Afro-Eurasian ecumene than did the latter, and materially shaped the greatest cosmopolitan-universalist imperial cultures of Western modernity’s eve.

Comparing Western Early Modernities

Praise be to God Who has made the opening of this West an opening of secrets, ... [which] virginal secrets are only deflowered by us [in the West]; only then do they come to you in your East as divorcees who have completed their waiting period, and you marry them....

IBN ‘ARABĪ, *EPISTLE OF VICTORY*²³

21 Melvin-Koushki, “Early Modern Islamic Empire.”

22 Many arguments have been made for and against various forms of Islamicate humanism, whether Greco-Arabic, rationalist or mystical; these are surveyed and critiqued, and a new umbrella concept of “Islamic humanism” proposed, in Marco Schöller, “Zum Begriff des ‘islamischen Humanismus,’” *Zeitschrift der Deutschen Mogenländischen Gesellschaft* 151 (2001): 275–320. The term *humanism* itself is notoriously difficult to pin down, and is often deployed polemically and/or vaguely. Hasse thus opts, not unwisely, for its strictest, most technical sense: European Renaissance neoclassicism. In suggesting the possibility of a common Islamic-Indic humanism, I am here conflating three broader senses of the term: fidelity to ancient precedent, preferably but not necessarily Greek, and often entailing a commitment to occultism; anthropocentrism; and the burgeoning of book and commentary culture—all features being quite pronounced in early modern Arabo-Persian and Sanskrit philosophy alike, and the former strongly philhellenic in its antiquarianism.

23 *Risālat al-Intiṣār*, in *Rasā’il Ibn ‘Arabī*, ed. Muḥammad Shihāb al-Dīn al-‘Arabī (Beirut: Dār Ṣādir, 1997), 338: *fa-l-ḥamdu li-Llāhi lladhī ja’ala fathā hādhā l-maghribi fathā asrārⁱⁿ ...*

The descriptor “Western”—like “the Renaissance”—has long been stumbling block and blinker both in the study of such early modernities, has served to disconnect Afro-Eurasian histories that were very much connected. At their most pernicious, invocations of Westernness but backproject violent colonialist lines onto the early modern intellectual-historical sand. The expansive framework proposed in *World Philology*, I full-throatedly agree, must be adopted if we are to philologically color outside, and ideally explode, these lines; but that volume nevertheless too trips on colonialist teleology in one crucial respect: it tacitly assumes Islam to be culturally un-West.

This narrative of *essential Islamic un-Westernness*, still ubiquitous in early modern intellectual historiography, radically betrays, distorts and even deletes our sources; its origin lies in Renaissance humanist anti-Arabism and anti-Ottomanism, and its modern justification is Enlightenment-colonialist, an ideology fatally hostile to all early modernities but one. To counteract this ideology, I propose that the broadest possible cultural-geographical definition of the West be consistently used when writing comparative early modern intellectual history: *the half of Afro-Eurasia west of South India*, incorporating the *Arabic, Persian and Latin cosmopolises*, that vast realm where the *Hellenic-Abrahamic synthesis* reigned supreme.²⁴ Other designations and categories are more appropriate to other structural aspects of early modernity, to be sure, a dazzlingly transformative age which saw the post-Axial, agrarian, Afro-Eurasian ecumene begin to interconnect and globalize in earnest; the focus

fa-lā taftaḍḍu abkārū l-asrāri illā ‘inda-nā thumma taṭla’u ‘alay-kum fī mashriqi-kum thayyibāt’ qad faraḡna ‘iddata-hunna fa-nakaḥtumū-hunna. On the theme of “West is best” recurrent in Ibn ‘Arabi’s works see Gerald T. Elmore, *Islamic Sainthood in the Fullness of Time: Ibn al-‘Arabī’s Book of the Fabulous Gryphon* (Leiden: Brill, 1999), 172–77. The westcentrism of the Doctor Maximus (*al-shaykh al-akbar*)—actually a Spaniard, unlike that other Doctor Maximus (*al-shaykh al-ra’īs*) Ibn Sīnā—was to be entirely justified by subsequent Islamicate developments, moreover: even persophone authors as far afield as Mughal India remained firmly committed to specifically Maghribi models, including in the first place Ibn ‘Arabi himself, and especially with respect to the occult sciences.

- 24 In this I follow Dimitri Gutas; see his forthcoming “The Intentions of the Philosophers, Avicenna and after: The History of Science Background” (my thanks to Professor Gutas for a copy of this draft article). See also Richard Bulliet, *The Case for Islamo-Christian Civilization* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2004); and Garth Fowden, *Before and after Muḥammad: The First Millennium Refocused* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2014). Cf. the fifth and final definition of the West as analyzed by Marshall Hodgson: “[S]ometimes all Afro-Eurasian *civilized lands west of the Indus* may be included, that is, roughly both Europe and the Middle East; for such a purpose, ‘west Eurasian’ or ‘Irano-Mediterranean’ is preferable” (*The Venture of Islam: Conscience and History in a World Civilization*, 3 vols. [Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1974], 1/54).

here is strictly on philology, in its various, genetically distinctive iterations, as an analytical category of great usefulness for the comparative macro- and micro-historical study of early modernity.²⁵ To borrow Sanjay Subrahmanyam's argument for the similar usefulness of *millenarianism* as a comparative category: philology, "like money, allows us to approach a problem of global dimensions, but with quite different local manifestations."²⁶

Western philology, then, by this measure, is at cultural core Hellenic-Abrahamic, its six great vehicles Greek, Aramaic, Hebrew, Arabic, Persian and Latin, and later local vernaculars like Turkish, Urdu and English. In the early modern West, its two primary trajectories, Greco-Arabo-Persian and Greco-Arabo-Latin, diverged to run powerfully and productively parallel. Such a cultural-geographical-linguistic definition is wildly reductive, naturally, like most analytical categories; yet it has the great virtue of manifesting the multiplicity of specifically genetically *Western* philological early modernities, long occulted from scholarly view by the reflexive, all-structuring assumption that (Latin) Christian Europe alone and forever constitutes the West. (Greek Christendom, of course, is already the Orient.²⁷) The designation Hellenic-Abrahamic also serves as a minimal typology for distinguishing early modern Western philologies from their contemporary Indic-Hindu and Sinic-Confucian cognates, for example, just as distinctively early modern, but contending with very different philosophical-scriptural patrimonies.

This is not to suggest that we dispose of the old East vs. West chestnut, which remains indispensable to the historical study of ideological frameworks; it was and is the primary rhetorical (and usually polemical) means for defining

25 Similarly, Sanjay Subrahmanyam has seminally proposed the *Tagus-to-Ganges* as a culturally coherent zone for the analysis of early modern millenarianism, messianism and apocalypticism ("Turning the Stones Over: Sixteenth-Century Millenarianism from the Tagus to the Ganges," *Indian Economic and Social Review* 40/2 (2003): 129-61).

26 "Connected Histories: Notes towards a Reconfiguration of Early Modern Eurasia," *Modern Asian Studies* 31/3 (1997): 750.

27 On medieval and early modern Byzantine scholarly culture, including its similar scholasticism vs. humanism tensions but differing Arabic and even Persian receptions, see *The Cambridge Intellectual History of Byzantium*, ed. Anthony Kaldellis and Niketas Siniossoglou (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017). Of particular salience in this comparative context is the neoclassicizing project of George Gemistos Plethon (d. 1452), which rather was radically philosophically *neopaganizing* and *anti-aristotelian*; see Niketas Siniossoglou, *Radical Platonism in Byzantium: Illumination and Utopia in Gemistos Plethon* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011).

different Wests to different ideological ends.²⁸ Indeed, the *tahqīq-taqlīd* binary presented here was precisely a philosophical-philological dynamic that historically served to both *orientalize the Occident* and *occidentalize the Orient*. East and West did not simply tryst geographically and textually in the middle of a passive, eternally medieval Islamdom, then go their separate ways; to the contrary, early modern Muslim philologists, like their Christian (and Jewish) peers, were heavily Western in their Orientation, as it were, and many actively Westernizing—a basic fact till now totally effaced in the scholarship.

It is thus unfortunate, because symptomatic of the very ill it treats, that *World Philology* lacks chapters on the two Islamicate cases most directly comparable to that of the Renaissance as examined by Hasse (and Anthony Grafton in the same volume)—that is to say, the most blatantly Western: the explosion of Arabic book culture and encyclopedism in the Mamluk Sultanate, and the philhellenic antiquarianism peculiar to Greco-Arabo-Persian philosophy in Safavid Iran. Here again, recent scholarship on these two cases has begun to lay the groundwork for such comparison, though a legitimately comparative philological study of Western early modernities is still many decades off.

Few historians would dispute the status of the Mediterranean zone as the beating cultural heart of the West, the circulation of whose Greco-Arabo-Latin textual blood first vivified and sustained, on the northern shores of that sea, medieval scholasticism, then the Renaissance itself, which featured the forcible “mediterraneanization” of authorities from the persophone east. *Printing*, as we all know, fed a boom in book culture wholly unprecedented in and unique to western Europe. But book culture similarly boomed on that sea’s arabophone southern and eastern shores—and in terms of sheer social impact hugely outstripped anything achieved to the north. Where the elite libraries of medieval and Renaissance Europe boasted hundreds of volumes, the local *public* libraries in Ayyubid-Mamluk lands boasted thousands; where thousands of books circulated in Italy or England, many *hundreds of thousands* circulated in Egypt and Syria. (That Arabic chroniclers of the era could speak fancifully of libraries with over a million volumes is here indicative.) This explosion of textual production necessitated, in turn, the production of works unprecedentedly encyclopedic in scope to navigate the new flood of Arabic knowledge, from classifications of the sciences and literary anthologies to chancery manuals and biographical dictionaries. I noted above how poorly Renaissance Latin works on famous men fare in comparison to their

28 On the polemical Westernization of Greece in particular, see e.g. Joel L. Kraemer, *Humanism in the Renaissance of Islam: The Cultural Revival during the Buyid Age*, 2nd rev. ed. (Leiden: Brill, 1992), introduction.

contemporary Arabic cognates, the former typically featuring mere dozens of entries and the latter thousands; the same principle applies to encyclopedic works in other fields, and epitomizes the massive disparity between the two great book cultures of the Mediterranean—that is, *the Far West*.

It is surpassingly ironic, then, that the same massive disparity has been preserved in the scholarship on early modern Arabic and Latin book cultures respectively—precisely reversed: many dozens of excellent studies—including Hasse’s—celebrate the rise of printing in western Europe; vanishingly few do the same for the mighty “postclassical” manuscript traditions of the arabophone, much less persophone and turkophone, realms.²⁹ (Classico- and arabocentrism, like eurocentrism, their parent, still plague the study of Islamicate civilization.) Yet clearly the long disinterest in printing in the Islamicate world did not cripple its book cultures in the slightest; indeed, a wide-scale adoption of printing, while known and very modestly deployed (in the Mamluk production of amulets, for instance), would have been precisely a hobble to and disruptor of the crucial sociopolitical functions of said cultures. Books, quite simply, *were more socially important in early modern Islamdom than in Christendom*: for there they enshrined and activated social relationships in fluid ways more rigidly substituted by university and church hierarchies in Europe. Such disparities of scale and function aside, however, and even at this

29 On Ayyubid-Mamluk book culture, see most notably Konrad Hirschler, *The Written Word in the Medieval Arabic Lands: A Social and Cultural History of Reading Practices* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2013); idem, *Medieval Damascus: Plurality and Diversity in an Arabic Library: The Ashrafiya Library Catalogue* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2016); and on Mamluk encyclopedism, see Elias Muhanna, *The World in a Book: Al-Nuwayri and the Islamic Encyclopedic Tradition* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2017). This culture, naturally, continued to flourish under the Ottomans; see e.g. İsmail E. Erünsal, *Ottoman Libraries: A Survey of the History, Development, and Organization of the Ottoman Foundation Libraries* (Cambridge [MASS]: The Department of Near Eastern Languages and Literatures, Harvard University, 2008); Nelly Hanna, *In Praise of Books: A Cultural History of Cairo's Middle Class, Sixteenth to the Eighteenth Century* (Syracuse [NY]: Syracuse University Press, 2003); and the collection of articles on and edition of Aṭūfī's (d. 1541) 1502 Ottoman palace library catalog (Hungarian National Library, MS Török F. 59), recording some 7,200 titles in 5,700 volumes, prepared by Gülru Necipoğlu, Cemal Kafadar and Cornell Fleischer and forthcoming as a *Muqarnas* supplemental volume. This catalog begs comparison with Gesner's *Bibliotheca universalis* of 1545, which features almost 10,000 Greek, Latin and Hebrew titles, extant or otherwise, as noted by Nühket Varlık in her article in that collection (“Books on Medicine: Medical Knowledge at Work”; my thanks to Professor Varlık for sharing a preprint copy of this article).

very early stage of research, we may declare, I think, a boom in book culture to be definitive of the early modern Mediterranean zone as a whole.³⁰

Unique to the same zone was the rise, from the 12th century onward, of *textual esotericisms and their equally textual disclosure*.³¹ This signal cultural shift is to be associated in the first place with the co-emergence of Hebrew *kabbalah* and Arabic *lettrism* in Islamo-Judeo-Christian Iberia and their parallel spread eastward around the Mediterranean basin; these gave rise in turn to such peculiarly early modern scholarly phenomena as *Christian kabbalah* in Renaissance Europe (Pico himself being its first exponent) and a renaissance of *occultist neopythagoreanism* throughout the Islamicate heartlands, and especially the Persianate east, processes which culminated in the 16th and 17th centuries.³² Once again, naturally, a massive disparity in scholarship on *kabbalah* and *lettrism* makes comparative study impossible, thereby disappearing it as a major structural component of a common Western—Helleno-Islamo-Judeo-Christian—early modernity. The study of *kabbalah*, habitually if bizarrely presented as a purely European phenomenon and neatly cleaved from its Mediterranean twin, now constitutes a veritable academic industry in its own right, while *lettrism* studies is formally nonexistent—this despite the fact that far more *lettrist* texts have come down to us than *kabbalist*.³³ As a consequence, the intellectual and cultural history of this

30 Islam Dayeh has likewise called for the study of this Mamluk Arabic philological revolution (“The Potential of World Philology,” 403).

31 See Moshe Halbertal, *Concealment and Revelation: Esotericism in Jewish Thought and Its Philosophical Implications*, trans. Jackie Feldman (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2007), 5. These developments may be considered a subset of the millenarianism and apocalypticism endemic to the Mediterranean zone as a unified whole, as Cornell Fleischer in particular has shown (see e.g. “Ancient Wisdom and New Sciences: Prophecies at the Ottoman Court in the Fifteenth and Early Sixteenth Centuries,” in *Falnama: The Book of Omens*, ed. Massumeh Farhad and Serpil Bağcı (London: Thames & Hudson, 2009), 232-43).

32 On *lettrism* (*‘ilm al-ḥurūf*), an occult science equal parts Hellenistic and quranic and associated in the first place with the Shi‘i Imams by Sunni and Shi‘i alike, as the primary vehicle of Islamic neopythagoreanism—and hence theoretical impetus for the new book and visual cultures of the early modern Persianate world—see Melvin-Koushki, “Of Islamic Grammatology.”

33 Taking as its point of departure that of Steven Wasserstrom, the work of Michael Ebstein (together with Sara Sviri) in particular is now challenging the unconscionable divorce of *kabbalah* from *lettrism* see e.g. his *Mysticism and Philosophy in al-Andalus: Ibn Masarra, Ibn al-‘Arabī and the Ismā‘īlī Tradition* (Leiden: Brill, 2014).

uniquely pan-Mediterranean development has yet to be written; but its import and impact seem to have been far-reaching indeed.³⁴

Of special significance for our purposes here is the fact that this age of esotericism served to invest texts with a new sociopolitical function throughout the early modern West. This period saw a large-scale transition from orality to textuality in the transmission of scholarly authority, as is well known; less well known is the fact that *esotericist reading groups* around the Mediterranean were responsible for recasting books—in this case lettrist-kabbalist treatises to be privately circulated—as *devices initiatory into the secrets of the cosmos*, as *means for achieving human perfection*. Inevitably, these occultist texts eventually escaped the control of their originary secretive reading communities, that is, were *de-esotericized*; and then, at least in the Mamluk context, they were *adabized*, that is, gradually literarily incorporated into the encyclopedic works of the age.³⁵ Yet even their exotericist reading audiences—including in the first place ruling elites—began to celebrate the initiatory function of books in their own right; rather dramatically departing from precedent, early modern Arabo-Persian scholarship thus features the widespread production of comprehensive, synthetic manuals on various sciences, occult or otherwise, that openly promise to free their scholarly or royal readers from the need for a teacher.³⁶ The roots of Ottoman deep reading, as studied by El-Rouayheb, are therefore to be traced to Mamluk treatises on lettrism in particular.³⁷

34 In terms of Christianate Europe alone, the Spanish Reconquista and Inquisition, which served to scatter Jewish scholars—among them many kabbalists—northward and eastward, did not simply precipitate the Christian kabbalah of Pico and others, but also helped inspire the *Hebraica veritas* ethos that would animate the Protestant Reformation itself. As for the equally epochal reverberations of lettrism in the early modern Islamicate context, especially with respect to the history of science, see below.

35 While studies of northern Mediterranean kabbalist reading communities are manifold, the only study to date of their southern Mediterranean cognates is Noah Gardiner's "Esotericism in a Manuscript Culture: Aḥmad al-Būnī and His Readers through the Mamlūk Period" (PhD diss., University of Michigan, 2014); on the emergence of a peculiarly Mamluk-Ottoman brand of occult-scientific encyclopedism in particular see idem, "The Occultist Encyclopedism of 'Abd al-Raḥmān al-Biṣṭāmī," *Mamlūk Studies Review* 20 (2017): 3-38.

36 As Gardiner notes in this connection, such lettrist manuals represent "a veritable *apotheosis* of the reader in an age of readers such as the Muslim world had never seen before" ("Esotericism in a Manuscript Culture," 340).

37 To be clear, this is my argument, not El-Rouayheb's; his study strictly excludes the occult sciences.

The Islamicate west was equally West, both geographically and culturally; but so was the Islamicate east. With respect to philosophy-science, indeed, the latter was ideologically more so: the post-Mongol Persianate world, centered on Iran, was scene to a surging *philhellenist antiquarianism* paralleled only by Renaissance humanism in Europe. From the 13th century onward, persophone philosopher-scientists increasingly invoked the Greek ancients, particularly Pythagoras, Socrates, Plato, Aristotle, Euclid, Ptolemy and the Stoics, and in some cases sought to textually retrieve them anew. (It should be noted, however, that only the Ottoman court actually sponsored new translations from Greek or Latin.) This second great Islamicate burgeoning of Greco-Arabism (after the epochal Abbasid translation movement)³⁸ culminated in Safavid Iran, and specifically with the so-called school of Isfahan, which achieved the synthesis of all preceding Islamicate strains of philosophical thought—Avicennism, illuminationism, Ibn ‘Arabian monism, Ash‘ari and Imami *kalām*—within a strongly Twelver Shi‘i traditionist-*cum*-antiquarian philhellenist framework: the transcendent philosophy (*al-ḥikma al-muta‘āliya*). This synthesis would enjoy hegemony through the colonial era, and informs Twelver Shi‘i seminary curricula in Iran and Iraq even today; it also drove the revolutionary project of Imam Khomeini (d. 1989) himself. Most notably, Safavid philosophy was powerfully *neoplatonizing* and indeed *neopythagoreanizing*—and thus rather divergent from the mainstream Renaissance philosophy reflected in university curricula, dominated as it was by Averroism.³⁹ Yet this divergence also represents a convergence: both traditions were obsessed with Aristotle, and especially his neoplatonist avatars; Pseudo-Aristotelica such as the *Uthūlūjiyā* (*Theologia Aristotelis*) boomed in popularity between the 15th and 17th centuries, in Iran as in Italy.

But the Safavid renaissance of neoplatonism and neopythagoreanism was driven by a very different need than obtained in Renaissance Europe, or indeed the competing Ottoman, Mughal and Uzbek Empires: the Safavid imperial project to *shi‘ize Iran*. Safavid philosophers—many of them also

38 The definitive study here is Dimitri Gutas, *Greek Thought, Arabic Culture: The Graeco-Arabic Translation Movement in Baghdad and Early ‘Abbāsī Society (2nd-4th/8th-10th Centuries)* (New York: Routledge, 1998).

39 On the Safavid context, see Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “World as (Arabic) Text: Mīr Dāmād and the Neopythagoreanization of Philosophy in Safavid Iran,” forthcoming. This is not to suggest that neopythagoreanism was not similarly an important feature of Renaissance thought, only that Averroism dominated institutionally; see Christiane L. Joost-Gaugier, *Pythagoras and Renaissance Europe: Finding Heaven* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2014).

high-ranking imperial religious authorities—accordingly sought to build a more robustly neoplatonic-neopythagorean platform in order to disentangle themselves from the Sunni theological tradition, long heavily Avicennan in orientation. As such, this strategy entailed the close identification of Shi'i doctrine with Greek—i.e., pre-Avicennan—philosophy; the striking Safavid *ad fontes* ethos was unprecedented in its call for a *textual* return to the Greeks and the Shi'i Imams in equal measure. A similar penchant for excavating earlier layers of the Western philosophical tradition, and especially the “pure” philosophy of the pre-Socratics, had of course been characteristic of the illuminationist strand of philosophy from the 13th century onward; but until the Safavid period such invocations of the ancients remained largely rhetorical, not textual.⁴⁰ This distinctive Safavid brand of antiquarianism and philhellenism—simultaneously philosophical in tenor and philological in practice—naturally gave rise to another boom in Islamicate book culture. Unlike that of the Mamluk realms, however, the Safavid iteration, both Arabic and Persian, centrally featured the production of philosophical anthologies designed to textually marry the Imams and the ancients.⁴¹

Safavid philosophers, in short, were *neoclassicizing progressivists* to a man. This paradoxically supersessionist form of philosophical perennialism is epitomized by the system of Mīr Dāmād (d. 1631), founder of the school of Isfahan, who famously structured it according to a historical binary reminiscent of the Greek vs. Arab model pushed by contemporary Renaissance humanists: *yūnānī-yamānī*, or Greek vs. Yemeni—i.e., occidental vs. oriental, rationalist vs. illuminationist. But the similarity is superficial: where the humanists' binary is expressly declinist, Mīr Dāmād's is progressivist, and posits his Islamic-Imamic philosophy as the culmination and total realization—*taḥqīq*—of the wisdom of the ancients.

What is Philology? The Problem of Cosmology

Here we come to the primary defect in the framework proposed in *World Philology*, these Mamluk and Safavid lacunae aside: its overmodest definition

40 Reza Pourjavady and Sabine Schmidtke summarize the state of the field and tentatively propose comparative study in “An Eastern Renaissance? Greek Philosophy under the Safavids (16th-18th Centuries AD),” *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World* 3 (2015): 248-90.

41 For examples of these, see Gerhard Endress, “Philosophische Ein-Band-Bibliotheken aus Isfahan,” *Oriens* 36 (2001): 10-58.

of *philology*.⁴² To define that art and science as the deep, disciplined reading of written texts and artifacts—that is, in purely *materialist* terms—is to radically truncate the epistemologically much grander category propounded by many of our early modern Western actors themselves, nonmaterialist panpsychist monists to a man. For them, as we have seen, philology, *taḥqīq*-and-*taqlīd*, entails various techniques of textual criticism, to be sure; but these must also be applied to our own human selves and to the cosmos as a whole—for *the world is itself a living text*.

The neat distinction in modern scholarship between two senses of *taḥqīq*—the first rationalizing and textualist, which is to say *philological*, the second theosizing and occultist, which is to say *mystical*—is thus simply, I submit, an artifact of reflexive Cartesianism, and hence useless as an intellectual-historical heuristic; it should not need saying that such mind-body dualism cannot be applied to pre- or non-Cartesian, mind-body monist texts and contexts without doing them extreme, colonialist violence. *Taḥqīq*, for many of its early modern Muslim (and Christian and Jewish) exponents, required the purification of the nonphysical “subject” (soul, intellect) to the same degree as, and in tandem with, that of the physical “object” (body, text), and philosophy-science was universally pursued as a spiritual-ethical, experientialist, *autophilological* practice.⁴³ We survivors of the Science-Religion wars that

42 Pollock's definition is here representative (“Philology and Freedom,” *Philological Encounters* 1 (2016): 14): “If mathematics is the language of the book of nature, philology is the language of the book of human being.”

43 Cf. William Chittick's call for its revival as such in *Science of the Cosmos, Science of the Soul: The Pertinence of Islamic Cosmology in the Modern World* (Oxford: Oneworld, 2007); on the *taḥqīq* vs. *taqlīd* binary see esp. 45–47. The early modern boom in popularity in the Persianate world of the occult science of physiognomy—whereby the human body was precisely rendered a text to be deeply read, with sweeping social, economic and political consequences—is of particular relevance in this autophilological context; see Emin Lelić, “Physiognomy (*ilm-i firāsāt*) and Ottoman Statecraft: Discerning Morality and Justice,” in *Islamicate Occultism: New Perspectives*, ed. Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Noah Gardiner, special double issue of *Arabica* 64/3–4 (2017): 609–46.

This is not to imply, however, the absence of dualist arguments against such a monist understanding of *taḥqīq*; many contemporary Muslim scholars certainly insisted on using the term in rather less universalizing, less *cosmic* a fashion. And by the late 17th century, even some partisans of Ibn ‘Arabian *taḥqīq*, in sharp contrast to their 15th- and 16th-century predecessors, were arguing for a more salafist, antirationalist interpretation of that category that specifically excluded philosophy (*falsafa*) from its purview (El-Rouayheb, *Islamic Intellectual History*, 285–94). But this and other similarly reductive interpretations did not attain to hegemonic status until the later 20th and 21st centuries—and only then due to their Protestant (i.e., neoclassicizing-declivist) resonance.

birthed Western scientific modernity must therefore be far more wary of blithely backprojecting the epistemic rupture that defines our cosmology onto the Western early modernities that preceded or rejected that rupture: for it is then that our philologist forebears rather fused scripture and nature in the quest for theosis.

The doctrine of the Two Books, of course, is a well-known feature of European medieval and Renaissance thought, and long celebrated by historians of science as a key theoretical driver of the so-called Scientific Revolution (more properly a mathematical one); it is perhaps most famously epitomized by John Dee's (d. 1608) stated quest for a *cabala of the real*.⁴⁴ But the same phrase, as it happens, precisely matches the semantic field of the Arabo-Persian term *taḥqīq* as deployed by many early modern Muslim thinkers. This includes Mīr Dāmād, for whom it is essentially tantamount to *lettrist neopythagoreanism*. As he states in his Persian summary of his philosophical system as a whole:

In sum: The realm of the letter corresponds to that of number, and the realm of number corresponds to that of engendered existence; and the relationships that obtain in the realm of letter correspond to those that obtain in the realm of number, which in turn correspond to the commixtures that constitute the realm of engendered existence.⁴⁵

Likewise a good neoplatonist, Mīr Dāmād accordingly posits the totality of macrocosm and microcosm together as constituting the Book of God, inscribed by the Pen or Universal Intellect, with all existents being letters, words, sentences, verses and suras in that cosmic scripture. And who are its readers? The *taḥqīqists* (*ahl-i taḥqīq*), says the Safavid sage, numbering himself prominently among them, a great cloud of ancient and modern witnesses—all Western—to the textual-mathematical nature of reality.

Such lettrist neopythagoreanism, such *cosmic philology*, epitomizes the Hellenic-Abrahamic synthesis that came to define specifically Western forms

44 See e.g. Håkan Håkansson, *Seeing the Word: John Dee and Renaissance Occultism* (Lund: Lund University Press, 2001); James J. Bono, *The Word of God and the Languages of Man: Interpreting Nature in Early Modern Science and Medicine* (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1995); Kevin Killeen and Peter J. Forshaw, eds., *The Word and the World: Biblical Exegesis and Early Modern Science* (Houndmills, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2007).

45 *Jazavāt u Mavāqīt*, ed. 'Alī Awjabī, with glosses by Mullā 'Alī Nūrī (Tehran: Mīrās-i Maktūb, 1380 Sh./2001), 133–34: *va bi-l-jumla 'ālam-i ḥarf bar 'ālam-i 'adad va 'ālam-i 'adad bar 'ālam-i kawn va munāsabāt-i 'ālam-i ḥarfī bar munāsabāt-i 'ālam-i 'adadī va munāsabāt-i 'ālam-i 'adadī bar mumāzajāt u mukhālaṭāt-i 'ālam-i kawnī munṭabiq-ast.*

of early modernity, whether Christian, Jewish or Islamic: for only the fusion of Greek mathematizing philosophy with Semitic (Hebrew and Arabic) scripturalism could fully fuse letter to number, and letter-number to being. That fusion was peculiar, moreover, to the Mediterranean zone—whence the Hebrew kabbalism of Pico and Dee, and whence the Arabic lettrism of Mīr Dāmād, whose gaze is unwaveringly western/Western.⁴⁶ It is this letter-number monism, I argue, that runs like a red thread through the otherwise diverse range of Western early modern philological revolutions, and most distinguishes them from their contemporary cognates elsewhere in Afro-Eurasia, as well as from medieval Western precedent: where Greek philosophy is predominantly mathematical and Sanskrit philosophy linguistic, Western cosmic philology is *mathematical-linguistic*.⁴⁷

46 Likewise, his philosopher-chemist colleague Mīr Findiriskī (d. 1640), a competent Sanskritist who spent many years in India studying yoga, was nevertheless firmly western/Western in his occult-scientific orientation; see Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “The Occult Sciences in Safavid Iran and Safavid Occultists Abroad,” in *The Safavid World*, ed. Rudi Matthee (New York: Routledge, forthcoming 2019).

47 As Pollock puts it in his introduction to *World Philology* (15): “[In the Sanskrit tradition,] the arts of language played the foundational role in intellectual life that mathematics played in Greece....” The epistemological consequences of this fundamental East-West scholarly divergence were profound and all-structuring, summarized by Kim Plofker as follows (*Mathematics in India* [Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2009], 12):

“[T]he Sanskrit tradition does not regard mathematical knowledge as providing a unique standard of epistemic certainty. For many Greek philosophers and their Islamic and European successors, a central concept was the abstraction of universal forms from their sensible manifestations in the same way that numbers and geometrical figures are abstracted from physical quantities and shapes. Hence the validity of mathematical knowledge has had profound implications for the nature of reality in western philosophical thought, from the Pythagoreans on down. It has been suggested that the corresponding role of “paradigmatic science” in Indian thought was filled instead by grammar (*vyākaraṇa*). In Sanskrit philosophy and logic, ideas about reasoning and reality are explicitly linked to the understanding of linguistic statements. What philosophers need to probe in such statements, therefore, is their grammatical interpretation rather than their analogies with mathematical entities.”

In other words, that Western cosmic philology effectively combines the Greek and Sanskrit models—a new brand of mathematizing neopythagoreanism that yet treats the grammatical structure of Arabic or Hebrew as modeling reality—suggests it as an early modern watershed without intellectual-historical precedent, and of the highest salience to any history of world philology. On a perhaps comparable synthesis of evidentiary scholarship and mathematical astronomy in the context of Qing China, see Benjamin A. Elman’s chapter, also in *World Philology*, “Early Modern or Late Imperial? The Crisis of Classical Philology in Eighteenth-Century China,” 239–42.

Nor was this radical form of philology merely an armchair pursuit (as philology today tends overwhelmingly to be); rather, it was consciously pursued as a form of *world-building*—and so drove the signal scientific and imperial developments that are the genesis of the very doctrine of Western exceptionalism. For only thus was the cosmos *mathematized*: first through the epochal mathematization of astronomy in the 15th-16th century Persianate world, then through the equally epochal mathematization of physics in the 17th-18th Latinate.⁴⁸ (Copernicus, Kepler and Newton, that holy trinity of scientific modernity, were thus but latter-day Arabo-Latin continuators of the far more vigorous Arabo-Persian astronomical tradition, as historians of science have now shown, and ardent neopythagoreans.⁴⁹) In both contexts it was Ptolemy himself who was subjected to the full range of philosophical-philological *taḥqīq*-and-*taqlīd*; and the Greek sage was only finally—if very incrementally and respectfully—subverted and transcended by committed neopythagorean-occultist cosmographers in particular, Renaissance humanist purificationism all notwithstanding.⁵⁰

Early modern Arabo-Perso-Latin astronomy-astrology, in other words, together with its sister mathematical-natural sciences, was precisely a mode of *imperial philological practice*, expressly if respectfully revolutionary, that aimed to reread—and rewrite—Western cosmology, to “[Enlarge] the bounds of Humane Empire, to the Effecting of all Things possible.”⁵¹ We philologists

48 So I argue in two recent studies: “Powers of One: The Mathematicalization of the Occult Sciences in the High Persianate Tradition,” *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World* 5/1 (2017): 127-99; and “World as (Arabic) Text.”

49 See e.g. George Saliba, *Islamic Science and the Making of the European Renaissance* (Cambridge [MASS]: MIT Press, 2007); F. Jamil Ragep, “Copernicus and His Islamic Predecessors: Some Historical Remarks,” *Filozofski Vestnik* 25/2 (2004): 125-41; Robert Morrison, “A Scholarly Intermediary between the Ottoman Empire and Renaissance Europe,” *Isis* 105/1 (2014): 32-57.

50 It must be emphasized that Copernican heliocentrism was considered by its proponents and opponents alike to be a *neopythagorean* doctrine, and hence firmly based on ancient Greek precedent. In other words, to again quote Dudney, early modern Arabo-Latin astronomers, like Persian poets, “maintained a tremendous respect for tradition while stretching that tradition’s fundamental assumptions to the breaking point and sometimes beyond” (“A Desire for Meaning,” 311). A firmly progressivist ethos was thus shared by Arabo-Persian astronomers and philosophers on the one hand and Persian poets and literary theorists on the other in their co-production of (an alternate Western) early modernity. On the intersections of literature and science, see e.g. James J. Bono, “Making Knowledge: History, Literature, and the Poetics of Science,” *Isis* 101/3 (2010): 555-59.

51 Thus Francis Bacon’s famous, and representative, declaration in *New Atlantis* (London, 1627), 31. For a critique of the standard tendency in the scholarship to elide the often

and historians of philology must therefore be more alive to the sheer historical potency of our discipline, deployed by our early modern forebears to *decode* and *recode* not just texts but the world itself. They took seriously, that is, and often successfully embodied, the neoplatonic notion of *sage-mage as architect of the world*. That this world-building was often accomplished by means of occult sciences like lettrism-kabbalah especially recommends them to our study. For in this age of totalitarian colonialist-capitalist hegemony, to be reflexively scientistic-materialist—i.e., occultophobic—in our understanding of what constitutes a text is to dance with the very devil that threatens the life of our discipline, now quarantined and starving in the ghettos of the corporatized Euro-American university. Materialist or otherwise, cosmologies have very physical consequences; this includes, of course, modern colonialist-capitalist cosmology, which magically rewrites all beings as mere consumption machines, then sets them to endlessly consume the world, all *mindless*.⁵² But as the historical record shows: radical philology can deconstruct all cosmologies and, weaponized, change them.⁵³

To restore philology to its wonted status as universal humanistic science and hence bedrock of the university—the mission Pollock rightfully enjoins on us in *World Philology* and elsewhere—, we must therefore formulate and propagate a more radical and cosmologically expansive definition thereof that transcends the narrow 19th-century physicalist scientism, peculiar to western Europe, that has so thoroughly humbled our discipline since. It is not enough to recoup and update the grandly generalist, Ārzuviān-Viconian philology of the 18th century, which ultimately failed to forestall the atomizing forces of nationalist golden-ageism on the one hand and scientistic triumphalism on the

explicit neopythagorean framework of early modern Western astrology—unfortunately exhibited too by Hasse—see Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “(De)colonizing Early Modern Occult Philosophy,” review essay on Liana Saif, *The Arabic Influences on Early Modern Occult Philosophy* (London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2015), *Magic, Ritual, and Witchcraft* 12/1 (2017): 98–112. On the early modern boom in Islamicate occult-scientific imperialism see my forthcoming *The Occult Science of Empire in Aqquyunlu-Safavid Iran: Two Shirazi Lettrists*.

- 52 On the *sorcerousness* and *unmodernness* of colonialist-capitalist modernity respectively, see e.g. Michael Taussig, *The Magic of the State* (New York: Routledge, 1998); Bruno Latour, *We Have Never Been Modern*, trans. Catherine Porter (Cambridge [MASS]: Harvard University Press, 1993).
- 53 A more recent case in point here is the *semiological pragmatism* of C. S. Peirce (d. 1914), which, like William James’s (d. 1910) *radical empiricism*, was expressly developed to destroy materialism as a viable Western cosmology.

other.⁵⁴ Against such enslaving sorceries, we need stronger magic, and stronger mages; we must train and mobilize new philology heroes to force a Copernican shift.⁵⁵ For *neopythagoreanism* would seem to be the Western cosmology best fitted to our neo-universalist cause—not least because Western modernity is itself now hegemonically *digital*, which is to say *neo-neopythagorean*.⁵⁶ The academy's linguistic turn of last century, stridently declinist yet curiously kabbalist, served to deconstruct that modernity; but it did not reconstruct it in habitable guise.⁵⁷ To build again the world, to add *coagula* to *solve* and so complete the Great Work,⁵⁸ a more constructive, cosmic-philological—i.e., mathematical-linguistic—turn is needed: a *Zukunftsphilologie*. Should not we too be paradoxically progressivist, be modern, by returning to our ancients?⁵⁹

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54 On Viconian philology, and Nietzschean counterphilology, see e.g. Timothy Brennan, *Borrowed Light: Vico, Hegel, and the Colonies* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2014).

55 Cf. Pollock's somewhat more cautious call for a "philology of the anthropocene, the epoch of potential planetary consciousness" ("Philology and Freedom," 19–20):

"[T]he heroic age of philology is past ... We do not need philology departments so they can produce philology heroes ... There exists ... what we might call a civic in contrast to an heroic philology, a way of reading, and hence of understanding the world, that strives to make us better members of the human community, a philology that aims toward what the late American philosopher Richard Rorty once called "the possibility of, or the obligation to construct, a planet-wide inclusivist community."

56 Melvin-Koushki, "Of Islamic Grammatology," 98–100.

57 A curious irony, given the explicitly occultist roots of structuralist and poststructuralist critical theory; see Jason A. Josephson-Storm, *The Myth of Disenchantment: Magic, Modernity, and the Birth of the Human Sciences* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2017), ch. 8.

58 Thus Alan Moore's alchemical-kabbalist critique of scientific modernity in *Promethea* no. 32 (April 2005).

59 Among the many calls in recent decades for a *return to philology* (e.g., Said, "The Return"), a *future philology* (e.g., Pollock, "Future Philology?"), a *new philology* (e.g., Jerome McGann, "Philology in a New Key," *Critical Inquiry* 39/2 (2013): 327–46), a *critical philology* (e.g., James I. Porter, *Nietzsche and the Philology of the Future* [Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2000]) or a *radical philology* (e.g., Aamir R. Mufti, "Orientalism and the Institution of World Literatures," *Critical Inquiry* 36/3 (2010): 458–93), my call here for rather a *return to new-old radical cosmic philology* is the only such, to my knowledge, to diagnose the rampantly successful epistemic virus that is materialist-physicalist cosmology as primary cause of the discipline's—and Western civilization's—current existential crisis.

But first we must retrieve them philologically; the depredations of Enlightened colonialism and neoliberal capitalism have so severely deformed, and continue to so do, global textual pasts as to render many of them illegible, whether through the physical destruction of archival collections or the institutional destruction of the philological expertise necessary to read them. Ironically, but tellingly, precisely the *Western* textual past is among those most grotesquely amputated—by Western intellectual historians themselves. Such a shocking act of *cultural autolobotomization*, pursued fanatically over centuries, can have few historical parallels; it is civilizationally suicidal, as is becoming increasingly clear. As that may be, the total orientalization of Islam has certainly saved Western philologists centuries of labor: far more than half of the massive Western archive can be safely left to rot—as worthlessly, terminally un-Western.

To restore the honor and integrity of Western philology and its history, thus so radically ideologically subverted, we need but dispense with the astonishingly bald fiction of *Islamic Otherness* first fabulated by a minority of humanist anti-Arabist philologists and just as astonishingly durable, because institutionally enshrined, since.⁶⁰ But we still lack a key adequate for deciphering the new, much larger map of Western early modernity that is thereby revealed. I have here proposed *taḥqīq* vs. *taqlīd*, progressivism vs. declinism, as that key. For it more neutrally expresses the cultural tension and dynamic so constitutive of the early modern Latin cosmopolis—and equally constitutive of the early modern Persian, encompassing the Ilkhanid, Mamluk, Timurid, Turkmen, Safavid, Uzbek, Mughal and Ottoman Empires, together with a host of lesser states east and west. Both cosmopolises, initially largely satellites or subsets of the Arabic, came into their own in the early modern period; but the Persian would be far vaster than the Latin, stretching from the eastern Mediterranean almost to the Pacific, and interpenetrating, uniquely, its mighty Sanskrit and Chinese neighbors.⁶¹ Given the dominant and intermediating position of

60 On the many modern weaponizations of this fiction see Cemil Aydin, *The Idea of the Muslim World: A Global Intellectual History* (Cambridge [MASS]: Harvard University Press, 2017).

61 The Persian cosmopolis also interfaced with the Chinese, though to a less notable extent. Some instances of Chinese-to-Persian translation in Ilkhanid Iran aside, moreover, textual transmission was largely in the other direction, and primarily through the translation of Persian sufi classics into Chinese, rather than Chinese classics into Persian; see Sachiko Murata, *Chinese Gleams of Sufi Light: Wang Tai-yü's Great Learning of the Pure and Real and Liu Chih's Displaying the Concealment of the Real Realm* (Albany: SUNY Press, 2000). The early modern period also saw a limited transmission and accommodation of Arabo-Persian astronomy-astronomy and medicine in China; see Dror Weil, "The Vicissitudes of

Islamicate societies within the early modern ecumene on the one hand and centuries of fantastical islamophobic misinformation on the other, to apply these two Arabo-Persian first-order terms to the Western whole would seem to only be fair.

The early modern West—and indeed Afro-Eurasia as a whole—thus shared a high cultural dynamic pitting neoclassicists against supersessionists; but that universal contest, naturally, had different outcomes in different sociopolitical zones. In sharp contrast to those of contemporary European humanism and equally neoclassicizing Chinese evidentiary scholarship (*kaozheng xue*), the Arabo-Persian philosophical-philological projects of a host of early modern Muslim scholars sought not to valorize classical models through the rejection of immediate scholarly precedent, but rather to valorize precisely that precedent as the *culmination*, *perfecting* and even *transcending* of classical models. Their perennialist casting of intellectual history assumed, in other words, not rupture but continuity, was not declinist but progressivist.⁶² Thus for Safavid scholars pre-Islamic wisdom culminates in early modern Islamic philosophy, an Arabo-Persian synthesis multiply transcendent in its marrying of the Imams to the Greek ancients on the one hand and Avicennism to Ibn ‘Arabian monism on the other; thus Mughal scholars edited or translated Mongol-era Persian and ancient Sanskrit texts in equal measure, and with their Sanskrit compeers vaunted operative imagination as the apotheosis of humanism; thus Ottoman scholars celebrated their status as the heirs of both Timurid-Mamluk learning and Greco-Roman imperial culture; and many of the same hailed neopythagorean lettrism the ancient-modern, Hellenic-Islamic core of the *philosophia perennis*.

It must be stressed, in sum, that the taqlīdist *ad fontes* ethos was in no way peculiar to Renaissance Europe, or peculiarly controversial there: it appears to have defined the early modern intellectual and cultural history of the Afro-Eurasian ecumene in general and its Latinate-Persianate subset in particular—and paradoxically drove the boom in taḥqīqism from India to England during

Late Imperial China's Accommodation of Arabo-Persian Knowledge of the Natural World, 16th-18th Centuries" (PhD diss., Princeton University, 2016). On the Sino-Islamic tradition more generally, see Kristian Petersen, *Interpreting Islam in China: Pilgrimage, Scripture, and Language in the Han Kitab* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2017).

- 62 The same principle applies to literary history, as noted above: the organic, progressivist continuity of Arabic and New Persian literature, like that of their Sanskrit and Chinese cognates, stands in sharp contrast to the catastrophic and rupturous form of change valorized in and unique to European literary history (Thomas Bauer, "Mamluk Literature: Misunderstandings and New Approaches," *Mamlūk Studies Review* 9/2 (2005): 105-32: 112).

the 15th to 18th centuries. The sources to be returned to were often radically different, to be sure, even within the compass of the West, and often radically changed in the returning; Arabism had many modes, as did its derivatives Persianism and Latinism, which in turn evolved largely in isolation from one another as vehicles of high culture. (Thus Averroism as a discourse peculiar to Europe, thus Persian alone as Arabic-Sanskrit interface.) But the upshot was everywhere the same, to wit, remarkable cultural and intellectual florescence, wherein *the cosmos itself was rendered subject to philology*: the Renaissances of Western early modernity.

Sed magis amica veritas: Toward a New Western Tahqīq

How sweet the breath spent searching, inquiring
widely into what and where the truth might be!
Set it as your standard in every case,
discern truth from untruth and leave the latter.
If in this wise you read every book
know how great your wage will be—
and if not, O thou wretch most vile,
this *new science* will stand witness against thee!

SHAYKH BAHĀ'Ī, 'ON TAḤQĪQ'⁶³

The story of *Success and Suppression* is still ongoing, as is testified to by the very existence of Hasse's admirable and exemplary study: it is willy-nilly obliged to assume an absence of Islamicate parallels due to the absence of parallel studies. Yet (Greco-)Arabism had its greatest *success* in the multiple Renaissances of Western early modernity, in the Persianate world as in the Latinate, in Isfahan as in Cairo, in India as in Italy—a basic fact still *suppressed* in the scholarship. It is thus simply not possible to adequately map, as Hasse sets out to do, the fault lines between ideology and science vis-à-vis the Greco-Arabic patrimony,

63 Bahā' al-Dīn Muḥammad al-Āmilī (d. 1621), better known as Shaykh Bahā'ī, was Safavid Chief Jurisconsult (*shaykh al-islām*) and renaissance man extraordinaire. These lines are from his famous didactic poem *Nān u Panīr* ('Bread and Cheese'), in *Kullīyyāt-i Ash'ār u Āsār-i Fārsī-yi Shaykh Bahā'ī*, ed. 'Alī Kātibī, intro. Sa'īd Nafīsī (Tehran: Chakāma, 1383 Sh./2004), 48-49: *ay khūshā nafasī ki shud dar justujū / bas tafahḥuṣ kard ḥaqq-rā kū bi kū // dar hama-yi ḥālāt ḥaqq manzūr dāsht / ḥaqq ū-rā dānist nā-ḥaqq-rā guzāsht // gar chunīn-i har kitābī-rā bi-kh'ān / 'āqibat ma'jūrī-yi khūd-rā bi-dān // var-na ḥaqq maqṣūd dārī ay khabīs / bar tū ḥujjat bāshad īn 'ilm-i ḥadīs*.

to “disentangle scientific motives from external ones” (308), on the basis of its Latin reception alone; a scientific control—*Persian*—is required. Any argument for excluding this requisite control cannot but be eurocentric in import; and eurocentrism, of course, is precisely an antiscientific ideology birthed in the Renaissance itself.

But this ideology is a problem far profounder and more insidious than Hasse allows; despite caveats, his very positing of a science vs. ideology binary smacks of materialist Cartesian dualism, that scion of declinist humanism, which is not simply an inadequate tool for excavating early modern nonmaterialist-panpsychist mindscapes—all of which but one, aberrant, do not and cannot lead to our own—but rather *a wrecker that razes their taḥqīqist temples flat*. Objectivity, philological or otherwise, never achieves neutrality; any explicit or implicit claim thereto is purest illusionism, a magic mind’s eye trick, similarly of Renaissance and especially Enlightenment vintage, that yet has very material, world-building applications.⁶⁴ Which is to say: ideology is illusionism, naturally; but illusionism too *is a science*, and an occult one at that. We must wield it, lest it wield us. As Pollock warns: “A double historicization is required, that of the philologist—and we philologists historicize ourselves as rarely as physicians heal themselves—no less than that of the text.”⁶⁵ While he declines to doubly historicize, however, the philological rigor and Arabo-Latin range so masterfully on display in Hasse’s study makes it indispensable to those early modern Western intellectual historians and genealogists who would so do, who aspire to both philological objectivity and undissembling partiality, who feel themselves morally bound to de- and reconstruct modernity along alternate, less civilizationally suicidal lines, who would call for a postcolonialist and postcapitalist “liberation philology.”⁶⁶

Success and Suppression is equally a goad: for it enshrines the wild imbalance, whose very origin it documents, that has so grossly deformed Western intellectual history, whereby Greco-Arabo-Latin culture self-evidently is of central importance but Greco-Arabo-Persian, equally self-evidently, is of none. But to rectify this imbalance, to cure this deformity, is a proposition staggeringly tall; it will take at least a full century of dedicated and strategic philological reconstruction before a companion study to Hasse’s on the early modern Islamicate context is even conceivable. A promising start has been made during the last two decades, to be sure; but the few Islamicists who are

64 On the impossibility, and undesirability, of scholarly neutrality, see Hodgson, *Venture*, 1/26-30: “On Scholarly Precommitments.”

65 Pollock, “Future Philology?,” 958.

66 Thus Pollock in “Philology and Freedom”; see also his forthcoming *Liberation Philology*.

also early modern intellectual historians have barely begun to make a dent in the massive corpus comprising many hundreds of thousands of relevant texts that survive by the many millions in manuscript and lithograph form, most of which have yet to even be *read*, much less published in modern editions. And these represent, of course, but a small fraction of the many tens of millions produced by the unprecedented, and long unparalleled, burgeoning of Islamicate book cultures in the post-Mongol era, which saw the proliferation of library collections far larger and richer than those in Europe—a basic and definitive feature of Western early modernity till now totally disappeared by the scholarly illusionism that is eurocentrism (an ideology usually, and ironically, occultophobic to boot), which presumes print culture to be the measure of Westernness. To recover, in short, such alternate Western early modernities—and hence build, perhaps, more viable and durable Western postmodernities—will require a philological revolution of our own: let us to the Arabo-Persian sources.

The moral of this early modern story: We Western intellectual historians of the Euro-American academy must no longer follow so blindly, so slavishly, our humanist forebears, whose narrow commitment to *taqlīd* still truncates our own *taḥqīq*, whose ideology still trumps our science.

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